Truth: Life and Crimes of an Expert Imperialist and his Red Right Hand

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34379737.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), All the canon ships

Characters:
Hordak (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Micah (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Angst, Post-Canon, Post-War, Imperialism, Aftermath of Violence, Hurt/Comfort, Damaged People Being Damaged, Trial for Hordak, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Hordak (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, literally everybody needs a hug, [catradora smut ch2]

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English

Series:
Part 2 of Season of the Survivor

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by AintGonnaHauntItself

Summary

The planet's wild magic has been released, giant magical plants and animals have overrun any infrastructure that might have been left after Hordak and Horde Prime, the entire global population has suffered decades of civil violence, an entire universe teeming with unknown entities is waiting just outside their orbit, and in every community in the world there are newly defected clone soldiers who are devastated, disoriented, and potentially violent. Etheria's heroes have been fighting so hard, for so long, but they still can't call the job done. Not yet, anyway. Not while there's so many open wounds left from a lifetime of total war.

Notes

Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with tough stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anybody for anything.
Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

See the end of the work for more notes

"...when critical thinking is the gateway sin."

Chapter Summary

> Life and Crimes of an Expert Imperialist and his Red Right Hand (i.e. Catra)

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.
> Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta had run off ahead of Adora and Catra, hair flying behind her and jabbering into a recorder with ever-boundless energy. "You could tell that was Hordak, couldn't you?" Adora asked the other woman softly in the dim light.

"Yeah," she answered quietly.

"You were his second-in-command for a while there. It kind of seemed like you guys got… I don't know if 'friendly' is the word," Adora struggled to articulate the question she was trying to ask.

"I never cared about Hordak and he never cared about me. We weren't ever nice to each other, and we didn't give a shit about the other's welfare." Catra's words sounded harsher than she'd intended, but thinking about that time in her life was painful for a lot of different reasons.

"Ah," Adora said awkwardly.

Catra wanted to leave it there, but she was also working on speaking her truth. Gross. "I… it… I liked that somebody finally saw that I was capable. For once. You know, like, good at what I set my mind to." She gripped an arm and scuffed at the ground with a clawed foot.

"I bet that was a really nice change."

"And…" Catra continued, slowly teasing apart the anger from her other feelings toward Hordak, "I think he was lonely, too. You know? Like he got the whole 'lonely at the top' thing," Catra said. Although, in hindsight, they were mostly lonely because they were both incorrigible assholes. "So, no we never gave a shit if the other was okay, just that we were doing our jobs." Catra thought for a few more moments and scowled. "And I'm still mad about when he tried to get me killed in the Crimson Waste."

"Is that why you were there? He sent you there?" Adora asked, looking upset.

"Yeah, he told me Shadow Weaver was too dangerous to keep around but instead of sending her to Beast Island, I kind of lied about it and let her escape, and he found out about it, and it was this *whole thing* ..." She rolled her eyes and made a bored noise. But now that she thought about it for the first time since before meeting Prime, Hordak giving her a chance to come clean was probably more than he'd ever been given. "He saw that as a betrayal, which like, *whatever,* and he sent me to the Crimson Waste. Which was supposed to kill me. Which was a total dick move."

"For sure," Adora agreed earnestly.

"But... even though he really scared the shit out of me that last day in the Fright Zone, I can't really blame him for trying to kill me that time," Catra said, trying to figure out why she couldn't just cut herself off from that entire period in her life, to get away from all of it.

“That small disagreement?”

Catra nodded and sighed. “I probably would have done the same if we swapped places. Actually... I know for a fact I would have done the exact same thing.”

Adora frowned at her, but for once Catra couldn’t tell what she was thinking.

Catra heaved another huge sigh and shook her head, unable to detach herself for some reason. “I don’t know why I give a shit, but… after everything that happened, I don’t want to see him hurt more. I know that seems kind of crazy, but… I don’t know.” She stalled, frustrated with how confused she was by her own thoughts and feelings, let alone how bad she was at expressing herself clearly.

“I don’t want to see him hurt, either,” Adora said as they walked. “I don’t want to see anybody else hurt at all.”

Catra grabbed her hand and pulled her to a stop. Adora waited with a slightly puzzled expression. “Look, I… I think I kind of feel like whatever the others do with Hordak, it would only be fair if they did it to me, too. And that scares me, because I want to stay and make this work.”

Adora picked up her other hand and squeezed it, listening intently.

“And I know you’ve been so stupid brave, and you’ve been through so much. *So* much. And I’m not trying to… uh, diminish your experiences or whatever Flower Girl says, but...” she willed her voice to remain steady but couldn’t keep herself from beginning to tremble again. “I’m sorry, but you just can’t know what it was like up there with Prime… what he did to us…” She blinked away tears and saw Adora’s eyes watering too. “Look, Hordak went through it too, and that’s not nothing to me. I don’t know why it matters, but it does.”

"It's because the real you is a good person, Catra," Adora insisted. When Catra kept her eyes down, she continued. "We're not going to let Prime have him. Prime is dead and gone, and we're in charge now. He didn't get to win with you, and he doesn't get to win with Hordak."

Catra finally looked back up at her. She wanted to say 'thank you' or 'I love you' but the words wouldn't come.

Of course Adora beat her to the punch. "I love you so much, Catra," she said, reaching up to swipe tears from Catra's cheeks with her thumb.

She threaded her fingers in the hair beneath Adora's ponytail and pulled her into a kiss. Adora wrapped her in a tight embrace, and they savored the moment before breaking apart.

"We should get back to the others, but…" a slight blush graced Adora's cheeks as she spoke in a voice barely above a whisper, "after the party, what do you say to an old-fashioned sleepover with me?"

Catra bit her lip and smiled coyly, stepping forward to press herself against Adora again. Just then, they heard Entrapta's high-pitched, mad scientist cackle from not far away and they both grinned. "Come on, hero, let's go get us some of the good life."

They slung their arms around each other's waists and headed for the lawns around Bright Moon, previously the site of the rebellion's camp headquarters, now the sight of rollicking festivities and rows of tents for clones.

Adora snorted and squeezed her as they reached the end of the trail. They found Bow, Melog and Glimmer on the outskirts of the party, chatting happily together while Entrapta, Wrong Hordak, and Swift Wind were talking nearby. Also in a loose ring around the main party were hundreds of clones, hovering uncertainly but looking better than they had at first. Here and there Etherians were already reaching out to them, some were wearing wreaths

of flowers, and it looked like a few had already been adopted, blinking down at their enthusiastic new companions in stunned confusion.

Just hours before, the clones had been so intimidating. They were huge, clawed, pupil-less, genetically engineered alien super soldiers turned... lost children? Catra couldn't help a stab of pity as she surveyed them. For a moment, she let herself imagine of the kinds of existences they and their brothers had led for thousands of years. Then she shuddered and shut her eyes tight, shaking her head lightly. She couldn't think of that. Not yet. Adora bumped her shoulder against Catra's and she startled and looked over at her. Adora smiled wearily. She was tired and hurting too, Catra remembered. She tilted her forehead against Adora's briefly before they refocused on the group around them.

Bow broke from his conversation with Glimmer. “Hey guys, keep an eye out for my dads. They just got here and they want to say hi.”

“That’s great!” Said Adora earnestly. "I think you'll like George and Lance," she added, looking at Catra as Melog watched attentively from between Bow and Glimmer.

“We should tell them sooner rather than later,” Catra countered, and saw Adora's smile flicker.

“Tell us what!?” Glimmer said, her eyes getting big and glassy.

Bow heaved a theatrical gasp. “What kind of news are we getting?” he squeaked, pulling his clasped hands to his face.

Catra probably shouldn’t have enjoyed crushing their hopes, but old habits die hard. “We need to figure out what to do with Hordak.”

“Oh,” Glimmer said with an immediate scowl and pout.

“ *Oh* ,” Bow said, looking concerned. “So, he’s surfaced in Bright Moon?”

"He was the clone that Horde Prime showed up in, up on the cliff," Adora informed them.

"Why didn't you tell us earlier?" Glimmer asked, though she sounded more curious than affronted.

"I don't know, I…" Adora gave an uncharacteristic whine of frustration, "I knew I would need to say something, but… it's not all as straightforward as it might seem. I was in his head for a minute there and… well it was *not* what I would have expected," she finished, shaking her head in confusion.

"Actually," Glimmer caught Catra's eye and she returned a meaningful look. "I was kind of wondering about him already."

Bow heaved a huge sigh. "I know nobody wants to think about the war right now, but if he's here in Bright Moon, we should act quickly. Last time he was seen on Etheria, it was by me, and *I* was stopping him from *killing you,* Glimmer. And that was after he'd destroyed his own lair with that arm cannon," he finished with a grim expression.

"Yeah," Glimmer said, "I know but, I just feel like there's a lot we don't know."

"Also, he may *actually* have lost his mind by that point," Catra said. In response to their puzzled looks she shrugged, looking sheepish. "When he found out what I'd done to Entrapta and that I'd been lying about it that whole time, he lost it. I mean, he *really* lost it. He was a wreck after she left… after I sent her to Beast Island, and we were both tired and stressed, but on that day I think he just stopped caring." Catra glanced around them, making sure their words weren't carrying too far in the noisy crowd.

The four of them looked at one another slowly. "He reacted that way over Entrapta?" Bow eventually questioned.

Catra pulled a face. "Sure, I mean, I'm pretty sure he thought she was dead. *I* thought she was dead."

“But like, over a *princess* ?” Bow pressed.

Catra narrowed her eyes and cocked her head, realizing their confusion. “Do you guys not know? About the whole…” she pointed her index fingers together with a raised brow and Adora gasped.

“What?!” Glimmer and Bow cried in unison.

“Back in the Fright Zone, people were calling them Lord and Lady Hordak.” Catra said, hugely satisfied with the juicy gossip she provided.

“No. Way.” Glimmer breathed in utter disbelief.

“No wonder she’s been looking for him this whole time,” Bow said, and nodded in response to the others’ questioning looks.

“Oooooohhhhhh,” Adora drew the word out slowly, “I get it now. *Wrong Hordak* .”

Catra smacked her palm to her forehead and held her other hand up to stop them. “Don’t get too carried away, though. I never saw anything explicit myself, and Entrapta never confirmed it. *But* …” she teased with a devilish grin. “Now- there’s a chance Entrapta made a nest in the vents- *but* , toward the end of her time with us, she wasn’t coming home to sleep in her own bed very often at all.” The others exchanged wide-eyed looks. She shook her head slowly and furrowed her brow before changing tac. “I mean, I always figured Entrapta was a not-so-secret superfreak, but *Hordak* ? Seven feet of creepy, murderous, rage-fueled, bat-monster?”

“But it’s not confirmed?” Glimmer asked with furrowed brows.

“There’s no hard proof, but I’d bet my li… well, maybe I’d bet Adora that he’s in love with her.”

“Hey!” Adora complained at the barb.

"You know I'm kidding," Catra said. "But seriously they were inseparable back then and he was definitely smitten from the start. It looks to me like they're both still into it." She shrugged.

"I don't understand," Bow said. "Not about the whole seven-foot bat-monster thing…" he didn't see Glimmer's brows shoot up. "But, seriously," his tone lowered, "Entrapta's made some bad mistakes, and she doesn't always make the best decisions, but Hordak is… he is *not* a good person. He was cruel, and brutal, and… what if… do you think he's manipulating her?"

Catra shrugged. "Maybe. She was easy for me to manipulate."

"Maybe she's just distracted by the fact that he's an alien," Glimmer suggested without conviction.

"Entrapta's no good-natured simpleton, guys," Catra said, "and Hordak is a lot of things, but I don't think he's been lying to her."

"But he's a *murderer* . How could Entrapta…" Bow trailed off.

"Well," Adora cut in, "so much has happened, though. I mean, just seeing what he came from has changed my perspective on Hordak *a lot.* "

"Watching what Wrong Hordak went through gave me a lot to think about too, but that doesn't change what Hordak did," Bow interjected.

Glimmer shrugged. "Like I said, there might be a lot we don't know."

"Catra, Adora, Bow, Glimmer! Are you guys ready to head out?" Scorpia called from over by Darla. They looked up to see that the other princesses were gathering around Entrapta by the ship.

"Coming!" Glimmer called. She looked at the others uncertainly. "How do we break the news?"

"No clue," Catra said darkly as Melog rubbed against her thigh. "Let's go."

* * * * *

The princesses, Bow, and Sea Hawk all crowded onto Darla. Adora even managed to get Swift Wind to agree to a short, inside-the-atmosphere flight. He seemed to have had a hard time on his feet the last time he was on Darla, so he laid on the ground by the captain's chair for the sake of stability. They all chatted happily, eagerly asking about the ship but glazing over at Entrapta's complicated explanations.

As the ship rose into the air and set off on its course, Catra sidled over to lean against the dash next to Entrapta while Melog hung out with Adora and a few other princesses, chatting together. "It's good to see how much fun you're having with this ship," she said, tail flicking lazily.

"Oh, and I *am* . Space is just so exciting. I know it'll probably be a while before I get the chance and I definitely have a few projects to wrap up beforehand, but I *can't wait* to explore more of the universe!" She was practically gushing, and Catra smiled genuinely at her lively enthusiasm. "Do you think Hordak would come with me? I kept thinking about him the whole time we were out rescuing you and Glimmer, and he just knows *so much* about *so many places.* I bet I could convince him."

Catra snorted. "I get the feeling he would follow you off a fucking cliff. I never thought I'd see Hordak so whipped as he was before I… she trailed off, both in shame and because she realized that the room had quieted. She looked around. Adora appeared tense, Glimmer and Bow seemed a little nervous. The rest of everyone wore stern expressions.

“Were you guys just talking about Hordak in the future-tense?” Mermista asked.

Catra and Entrapta exchanged a look from the corners of their eyes. “Yes, yes I was,” Entrapta said in a frank tone.

Mermista raised a brow. “And why would that be?”

Catra started getting nervous. Melog came to bump his face against her hand, mewling. She trusted that Adora wouldn’t let her come to harm, but she didn’t like their situation one bit. Two high-ranking ex-horde members talking about a future that involved their disgraced commander in a room full of princesses might have been a bad idea. “Because he’s my lab partner, and I have a lot of hopes for our future,” Entrapta replied calmly.

Damn, Catra thought, she’d grown even bigger balls in her time on Beast Island. Not for the first time, she wondered just what the odd little scientist was truly capable of.

“You can’t be serious,” Netossa said, staring at them both. “Entrapta, I thought you had learned better. I thought you were committed to change.”

“Yeah, I don’t understand. I thought you’d seen the error of your ways or whatever,” Mermista said, her face growing darker by the second. “He’s the reason we went through *all* of this.”

Catra stood up and felt Melog bristle as she edged closer to Entrapta, resisting the urge to place herself between the small woman and the agitated crowd. She kept telling herself to trust Adora and stay calm, but her survival instinct was screaming in panic at the idea of being surrounded. She felt cold sweat bead up on her brow. There was just *so damn many* of them. She couldn’t fight them all off, no way. Maybe she could convince them to hold off long enough to land the ship, but… Catra let out a breath of relief when Adora came and placed herself squarely between both she and Entrapta and the rest of the room. “The clone that was on the cliff, that I cast Prime out of- that was

Hordak," she said. The others exchanged glances, unsure of what to make of the statement. "And I think there are some things we need to discuss and some questions we need to ask him before we make a decision on what to do with him." She stepped aside to re-include Catra and Entrapta in the group and Bow put his hand on Entrapta's shoulder.

"I know he's hurt you all terribly," Entrapta began slowly. "I know we did bad things, and I don't expect you to understand, but…" she took a deep breath. "I'm asking you, as my friends, to trust me when I say he's worth keeping. He's my partner. I haven't given up on him yet and I don't plan to." She finished with a quieter voice than she'd started with, but her expression remained firm.

Mermista groaned loudly. "Uuuuugh, I was really hoping that guy would have just disappeared by now! Why did he even come back?"

"I don't know, but I wonder what he wants," Perfuma said curiously, putting a hand on Scorpia's arm and peering up at her conflicted expression curiously.

"Who cares? That guy is overdue for some butt-kicking!" Frosta said gleefully, punching a fist into her other palm.

"Right, okay, but *then* what?" Mermista drawled. "Are we going to figure out a way to get rid of him somehow?"

"No, we're not." Entrapta broke in. "At least, I'm not. Hordak stays with me. We stay together. Nobody's going to throw him away again." Her eyes were fierce, but her voice stayed calm. Glimmer shifted on her feet uncomfortably as the princesses exchanged looks of shock with each other and Entrapta. Catra had to smile at the scientist's sheer nerve.

"He can't have any access to his old supporters or any kind of tech, and there's not a territory on Etheria that doesn't consider him an enemy." Netossa said.

"We haven't even heard his side of the story, yet," Adora interjected.

" *His side* ? Why would we need to hear *his side?* Hordak was a force of evil and he deserves to be taken down like Prime," Mermista said, tone dripping in venom.

"I don't know that he is evil, though," Catra suggested and Adora nodded in agreement.

A shocked Mermista addressed Adora as if Catra hadn't spoken. "What do you mean not evil? Don't you remember what he did? He attacked *civilians,* Adora. He hurt *kids.* He left nothing but destruction and devastation in his wake, and he *enjoyed* it." Her reaction was mirrored in the expressions on several other faces as well.

"Don't forget he had child-soldiers," interjected Spinnerella.

"Didn't he hurt Catra at some point, too?" Scorpia brought up with an apologetic look at Entrapta.

"What?" Adora asked in shock, turning to stare at Catra. Her voice lowered dangerously. "He put his hands on you?"

Catra blanched. "What?! No! Ew, no, it was a forcefield type situation. Gross," she shuddered, trying not to think of Prime.

"I thought you got away when he found out…"

"Okay," Catra answered, now annoyed, "A- I didn't 'get away', I fought him and I won. And B- He did suffocate me until I blacked out that one time, *yes* . But, I mean, come on. It's *the Fright Zone* . Shadow Weaver would have pulled something like that on me if she was bored on a Wednesday, but that didn't stop you from taking *her* back. In fact, Shadow Weaver had already joined your side when you brought her back into the Fright Zone and she faced me again." Catra couldn't help a thrill of rage and bitterness as she remembered a day she'd been trying to forget ever since. She looked around and tried to keep the accusation out of her

tone. “She just needed me out of the way. She or Bow or Glimmer could have just knocked me out. But instead, she hurt me. She hurt me until I gave up fighting back.” It had been nothing compared to what she went through at the hands of Horde Prime, but she could vividly recall the shocking, breathtaking pain. Being levitated and constricted, with absolutely no way to fight back… it had been yet another tally in Catra’s mental ledger against the princesses and their professed *moral superiority.* “Bow and Glimmer saw that, and it didn’t make a difference to you people so long as she was useful to you. You kept her until the end. What counts as ‘evil’ depends on your *agenda*, is that it?”

Adora didn’t argue against Catra’s point, but she didn’t seem happy about it.

“That was different,” Glimmer argued, “We didn’t give her a second chance because she deserved it. We didn’t forgive her and we *didn’t* trust her. We took her in because we needed her.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Not that you need Hordak, but nobody said you had to forgive or trust him, either. It’s not like all of you forgive and trust me, but I’m making it work.” She shrugged and looked away.

“Okay, well, regardless,” Mermista said, “We already know from those actions that Hordak is *not* a good person. You just don’t do stuff like that unless you’re a jerk who doesn’t care about anyone or the value of life itself.”

“That’s not necessarily true.” This time, Perfuma addressed the group. “I know we all want to believe that only bad people do bad things, but it’s just not that simple.” She glanced up at Scorpia before continuing. “I’ve been thinking about this a lot, actually. I know this is a really scary thing to think about, but it’s very, very easy to be wrong. Sometimes totally decent people can do really terrible things because the world has been so twisted up around them that they don’t realize they’re doing anything wrong.” She glanced at Scorpia again, who nudged her shoulder affectionately. “ *Some* of us know enough to question the things we do from

outside perspectives, and search out the truth of right and wrong," she nodded toward Adora, who rubbed her arm in obvious discomfort. "But for the vast majority of us," she looked back up at Scorpia, "our highest instinct is to take care of the ones we love and make them proud of us. And that's not a bad thing, but sometimes it gets a person into the wrong side of trouble." She smiled and leaned her head delicately against Scorpia's exoskeleton.

"'Kay, cute, but literally none of that has anything to do with Hordak," Mermista droned.

"I don't know," Catra spoke again, "from what I saw on the Velvet Glove, I think you might be wrong on that one."

Mermista glared, Catra averted her eyes, and Adora put a hand on her shoulder. The rest of the princesses gave each other searching glances.

Swift Wind spoke from the floor. "Look, I've never been Hordak's biggest fan, but in defense of all the clones, I'll remind you that oppressive regimes reproduce themselves by creating subjects who are conditioned to embrace and replicate the paradigms of the dominant system."

Several princesses gave him blank stares.

He sighed and tried again. "Prime had a long time to perfect what he did- you saw how good he was at it. Sympathy, empathy, familiarity, individuality, creativity, self-expression… anything that might have undermined his control- he stamped it out of his clones before they ever even interacted with anybody else. And it's not exactly easy to challenge a faith-based superiority complex when the alternative is unspeakably horrifying, and critical thinking is the gateway sin."

Nobody had anything to say to that. Entrapta moved for the first time in a while when she lowered her mask and turned back to the dash. Catra hoped that the arguing was over. After a few

moments, however, Frosta spoke up. "Well, if Wrong Hordak is a good guy, why didn't Hordak become a good guy? He didn't *have* to be a bad guy."

"Excellent point, Frosta," Mermista said, nodding at the girl.

Again, it was Perfuma who objected. "I know you don't want to hear this, but Wrong Hordak went straight from having his brain fried on Prime's ship, right to being accepted by a group of loving, supportive people who happened to be on the right side of the war. We have no idea what happened to Hordak before he became Hordak."

"Also," Bow said grudgingly, "Wrong Hordak was forced to realize Prime was a liar because we took him to the place where the cover-up happened. He was still super zealous all the way up to that point. In fact, he was only helping us because we told him we were working for Prime." A round of murmuring swept the group and Mermista crossed her arms, scowling.

"Inculcation is a difficult trap to escape from," Perfuma offered sagely.

"Whatever that means," Mermista grumbled.

Perfuma opened her mouth to explain despite Mermista's petulance, but Bow cut her off. "Alright, regardless of how any of us feel, we still have to figure out what to do with him. And that'll probably include us having to keep him out of trouble."

"That is *so* not our job," Mermista complained.

"It shouldn't have to be, but what can I say? The guy is a self-starter," Bow replied with a helpless shrug.

"Alright, we all have to get together again tomorrow anyway, and we've already discussed how we're going to address our problems and move forward. How about we summon Hordak to our meeting, place him under a truth spell, get the information we're missing and whatever else we need to get out of our systems, and

then we can all make a more informed decision?" Glimmer suggested. She looked very tired. As she waited, nobody objected.

Entrapta was staring straight ahead, gloved hands pressed to the display in front of her. Scorpia and Perfuma exchanged worried looks. "Entrapta," Scorpia said gently, "don't worry about Hordak. I'm sure everything will work out eventually."

"Huh?" Entrapta asked, flipping up her welding mask and turning to give Scorpia a blank stare for several seconds before registering what she meant. "Oh! Hahaha," she gave a short, sharp, nasally laugh. "I'm not worried about Hordak! I said he wasn't going to get thrown away again and I meant it." She lowered her mask and turned her head back to face forward. "I'm just wondering how many friends I'll have left by the time he and I walk away from this."

Everyone on board stared at the back of Entrapta's head in open-mouthed shock for several seconds before exchanging stunned looks. Catra couldn't help but raise her eyebrows and smile again at the feisty scientist who had grown so much stronger and braver since they'd first met. A few of them seemed to start to say something, but nobody actually did. Entrapta began humming tunelessly and the seconds dragged, tension mounting.

"Ding ding ding!" Entrapta cried, making several people jump. They could hear the ship beginning to slow and several people breathed sighs of relief. "First stop, Spinnerella and Netossa, this is you!" She slammed her hand down on a section of the dash and the spaceship lurched to a stop, sending everyone who wasn't holding onto something stumbling into one another.

Chapter End Notes

> Lots of nods and references to other stuff and probably some borrowed shit throughout, just because I've soaked it up at some point and I either don't realize it or I don't remember where I got it. If you recognize what something comes form, please make mention of it in a comment or something. I'm

not trying to be an asshole, promise.
If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.
Cheers.

“Holy shit I’m so glad we’re not trying to kill each other right now,”

Chapter Summary

> The night of the finale, as quiet and darkness descend, the future looms large and overwhelming. Tender words are exchanged and tender moments pass. (catradora smut ahead)

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves.
> Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora, Glimmer, Bow, Melog and Catra were chatting in low voices outside of what Catra understood to be Adora’s bedroom. Glimmer had budged up next to Bow and wrapped an arm around his waist while she turned their conversation from her budding new relationship with her father, to the more comfortably familiar territory of teasing Catra. “You know, when Adora was fresh out of the horde, Bow and I kept her company because she wasn’t used to sleeping alone.” She grinned as Bow laid his arm over her shoulders. “I don’t suppose you’d want us to keep you and Adora company tonight, would you?”

“Thanks, Sparkles, but I think I can stand the terrors of Bright Moon long enough to catch some shut-eye without you standing guard,” Catra said sarcastically. “As for company,” she shot Adora a sideways look. “I’ve got all the company I need, thanks.” Melog

mewled up at her. "Yes, that means I'd like some privacy." They blinked up at her, twitched an ear, sneezed, and walked away. "No need to be huffy, " she called out after them. Tease though she might, Catra could tell they were looking forward to exploring Bright Moon. And Catra was looking forward to the gossip an invisible cat might bring back.

Adora raised an eyebrow at the other two. “Speaking of company, Bow, we passed your bedroom without you saying your goodnights.”

Bow blushed and smiled sheepishly. “My dads are in that room while they’re here. Glimmer’s letting me share her room while we figure things out.”

“Just sharing the room, then? What, are you going to sleep on the floor or something?” Catra asked.

“It won’t be the first time I’ve shared my bed with him,” Glimmer said, giving them a gratuitous wink before spinning Bow around and sauntering away with him.

Adora and Catra exchanged raised eyebrows before Adora opened the door. “After you,” she said, gesturing her in.

Catra raised an incredulous brow yet again as she passed Adora’s goofy, smiling face. Once her back was safely turned, she allowed herself a brief, fierce grin. Then she arranged an appropriately haughty smirk and turned as Adora shut the bedroom door behind her.

She stretched languidly as she surveyed the room; typical of the rest of Bright Moon, ridiculously spacious, and opulent to the point of offensive frivolity. “This is some place, you’ve got here.” Catra immediately cringed inwardly at her absolute shit small talk. 'Some place'? What was she, Kyle?

Adora's smile had faded and now she didn’t seem to know what to say. Catra cast about for something to break the tension, but it was difficult. Suddenly the enormity of all that had passed

between them seemed to bubble up and congealed the air in the room. Catra wanted the mood to be light and easy, but now that Adora's demeanor had shifted, she began to remember when and where they were. She started to remember their long day, how close Adora had come to dying, how… how *resigned* she'd been. The hair on the back of Catra's neck stood on end.

The awkward silence stretched on as they stood, shifting between eye contact and looking at random points all around the room, fidgeting in uncomfortable silence. Adora finally spoke, laughing nervously. "I guess it's been a little while since our last sleepover."

Something about her words devastated Catra in that moment. The forced familiarity of it, the sterile approachability… made the distance between them more obvious than anything else yet. It made Catra want to scream. She wanted to start listing off the reasons why Adora's fake nonchalance was complete bullshit, wanted to make her feel bad for the condescending dismissal of all that lost time. Instead, Catra whispered with bitter tears in her eyes, "I missed you."

That was all it took. Adora reached her in three strides and they wrapped each other in a desperate, clinging hug. Adora buried her face in Catra's short hair, and she turned her own face into Adora's neck. They stood there for what must have been minutes, getting ahold of their thoughts and emotions. Adora moved an arm to start stroking Catra's back, slow and soothing.

"I did a lot of bad things," Catra said thickly. "I hurt a lot of people." She sniffed and clenched her jaw against threatening sobs. "I've made a lot of mistakes."

"None of us are coming out of this with clean hands. None of us made all the right calls."

"You know it's not the same."

"I know." They fell back into silence, still holding each other, but this time the quiet was more comfortable. "I never stopped

missing you. I missed you so much, I thought about you all the time, I…" Adora huffed a small laugh, "I used to get so mad when I dreamed about you." Catra rubbed her cheekbone on Adora's shoulder, trying to press even closer. Adora sniffed her hair and lifted hand to trail fingers along her ear, making it flick repeatedly. "It didn't help that you just kept getting hotter."

Catra finally loosened her hold and pulled back, smiling again. "It was probably all that spite. It really kept me kicking till I got it knocked out of me." Catra lifted her eyes to Adora's, but she was looking off to the side with a furrowed brow. Adora opened her mouth, then closed it, scowling and avoiding eye contact. Catra waited, but Adora didn't explain herself. "Spit it out," Catra encouraged.

Adora huffed a frustrated sigh. "Catra… I… are you okay?" Adora seemed to be forcing herself to talk, squinting at Catra's shoulder and speaking with a surprisingly small, uncertain voice. "I mean, of course we don't have to talk about everything that happened yet, obviously, but-"

"I'm fine Adora," Catra assured her, stepping back and running her hands over her upper arms, trying to banish the goosebumps there. "Don't kill the mood now, we just won."

"I know, but… I mean you were with Prime, like, *days* ago." Catra immediately felt the familiar plummeting feeling in her chest. "I don't know what he did to you, but you got chipped, and-"

She set her jaw and held her breath, interrupting again. "I'm. *Fine.* Adora."

Adora took a step closer, and Catra took an involuntary step backward, cursing herself for the concession. "Look," Adora began gently, "I've spent the last few years just trying to get control over my life and… I remember how bad it felt when that crazy First Ones-murder-virus infected the sword and I attacked you…" she trailed off, chewing her lip.

“Could you remember what you did when you got all kill-happy?”

Adora shook her head, looking at her intently. She must have known from her moment in Hordak’s mind that the chipped were fully aware, even as Prime controlled them. “I can’t imagine what it must have been like for you, but-”

“It sucked. Not much else to say.” She appreciated that Adora was trying, but she would never know. How could she? They’d both been manipulated, coerced, threatened, even magicked into doing things they didn’t want to, but none of it compared to what had happened on the Velvet Glove. Catra shuddered, Adora noticed.

“Catra, this is what I’m talking about. I’m… I’m scared of what you’re going through. But I’m a lot more scared of the idea that you’re dealing with it alone.”

Catra lifted her eyes and, to her own surprise, felt them burning with gratitude. “Thanks, Adora. Really.” She was unable to stop her gaze from flicking down to Adora’s lips, flushed pink from her worrying at them. “But… can we just be happy right now? I need that. I *need* to feel that we made it. Both of us survived.” She gave Adora a pleading look and was rewarded with a dazzling smile.

“Of course. Just… just know that I’m with you, okay? And I’m not going anywhere.” Adora pulled her into another tight hug. “Let’s clean up and get in bed. And don’t tell anybody we use the waterfall for showering, because I never figured out how they do that here and they’ll definitely laugh at you." Catra laughed out loud at her and she continued with a smile. "But come on, who even has time for baths, anyway?”

They showered together, quickly and efficiently, trading curious glances that neither tried to hide. For a moment, Catra had been worried that it might be awkward after so much had passed between them, but they’d shared showers in the horde and even though it had been years, they’d fallen into their old comfortability easily.

As they prepared for bed, Catra studied Adora's frame. Her body was different after years of separation, and Catra knew hers must be too. They'd both rounded the final stretch of puberty during the worst of the war, and she imagined that neither of them had paid much attention to the changes. Catra was torn between the desire to examine every delicious development Adora had made, and burning guilt over being the reason for Adora's most distinctive battle scars. Faint parallel scars shone in the light from her face, arms, and back as she moved. Catra didn't have any obvious marks from injuries that Adora had done to her. Then again, Adora had never done her lasting injury.

She couldn't help but smirk slightly when the other donned bed clothes that Catra fully intended on removing shortly. She donned the old nightgown that had been thrown at her out of courtesy alone. It was one of Glimmer's old cast-offs, by the looks of the color scheme. She could see the frayed edges around the armholes and bottom edge that marked where Adora had ripped off frills.

She was smirking at her own reflection when Adora lowered the lights. She looked around and saw her beckoning from beside her canopied bed, nervous smile back in place. Catra's stomach fluttered at the sight, and she was forcibly reminded of the turn their sleepovers had taken shortly before Adora had deserted. They'd been so intimately connected since childhood that even Catra took a long time to realize that Adora was a very precious kind of friend. But when Adora had finally pulled the confession out of her, she'd said she felt that their bond was special too. That it would keep them strong forever, and they'd never have to be scared of anything because each had the other. And Catra had believed it so completely that her entire sense of self shifted to anchor in that dream. She knew in her very bones that she and Adora had what it would take not just to survive, but to use all they'd learned in the Horde to win, to prove everyone wrong, and to *thrive* .

And then it was all over. Whatever her new friends had put in her head in just a few hours' time, it was enough to leave everything

behind. Their team, their mission, their careers, their future…and Catra. She was just gone, and suddenly it wasn't Catra and Adora against the world anymore. Instead, Adora had decided to be the good guys' hero, which made Catra a de facto villain. And for all he'd lied about, Prime wasn't wrong when he said that villains aren't worth staying for, let alone fighting for.

` *Stop. Stop right now* ,' she commanded herself harshly as she watched Adora crawl forward on the bed, disappearing beneath the drooping canopy. Now was not the time to feel sorry for herself. Now was the time to celebrate their win and get freaky with the most amazing girl on the planet, who was still rustling and shifting on the bed.

She'd never admit it to anyone but Adora, but looking back, she'd been in love all along. The jealousy from other cadets, the venom from Shadow Weaver, even constantly being one-upped by her, it had all been nothing compared to how happy Adora made her. Less than twelve hours after confessing her love, she knew that no matter what had passed between them, it was all still true and more. She loved Adora with every fiber of her being, even the fibers that had hated her for years. Whatever came their way-together, they were up to it. The bed squeaked lightly as Adora continued to shift behind the curtain, making Catra's ear twisted before she took a deep breath, straightened her spine, and approached.

She burst out laughing when she rounded the canopy's entrance and saw Adora. She had wrapped her blanket around herself and up over her head, and was sitting on top of the rest of her twisted bedding.

"I tried laying down, but it felt weird," Adora explained with an awkward smile, "but sitting up also felt weird? I don't know, I tried a few different things and-"

"Chill, Adora," Catra muttered, "come here." She held out her hand and helped Adora out of the blanket onto her feet. Adora crossed her arms and fidgeted on her feet while Catra shook out the

blanket and lay it back over the sheets, trying to suppress the grin that threatened at the corners of her mouth. "Now use the sheets you fucking savage," she said, finally breaking out into a wide smile as she held the covers up for Adora to crawl under.

Adora grinned back before tunneling under the bedding as if she were a kid in a pillow fort. Catra followed her under the covers and squeaked when Adora reached out and grabbed her, yanking her forward and wrapping her in a tight hold. They twined their legs together and Catra nuzzled her face into Adora's chest while they fought over warm spots with their feet for a while. Adora dug her fingers through her hair and pressed a kiss to the crown of her head, cradling her closer while Catra's tail flicked. As their sheets warmed and the bed grew more cozy around them, Catra felt a low purr start up in her throat.

When Catra finally lifted her faintly glowing eyes up to meet her gaze, Adora smiled nervously and made a few awkward faces. "So..." she muttered painfully.

"Hey, Adora," Catra whispered silkily. Here in the dark and comfort of Adora's embrace, she felt herself entering her element. She slowly grabbed handfuls of Adora's oversized shirt in her fists and her tail twitch and swish more fervently. Adora smiled and blushed, and it was an utterly devastating thing to see through the gloom. Catra scooted up as close as she could and pressed her forehead against Adora's oversized one. "I almost lost you today. Never again, okay?"

"We almost lost everyone today," Adora corrected gently. But Catra could finally hear it- the note in Adora's voice that signaled she knew full well that she was bullshitting. Her denial had grown too brittle to maintain in such an intimate setting.

Catra lifted a hand from Adora's shirt to cup her face, waiting for her to meet her eyes again. Adora's blue gaze was wide and watery and earnest as Catra spoke firmly. "You were the one on the floor letting the heart kill you. You were the one that was never supposed to live through what the First Ones did to Etheria.

To you.” Adora’s forehead puckered and the corners of her mouth pulled back, but she maintained eye contact. “It doesn’t matter how close anybody else came, what happened to you today will never, ever be okay.” Her face crumpled and she pulled Catra back against her chest.

Catra felt Adora’s suppressed crying rather than saw it, and this time it was her turn to comfort, to coo and pet and kiss. “I didn’t want to do it,” the other whispered miserably.

“I know.”

“I wanted to stay with you. You know that, right? I didn’t want to go.”

Catra’s own tears spilled forth and she grimaced at the sting. “Sh… I know. You were so, so brave.”

“I was so scared,” she sobbed, shaking now. “I didn’t want to die.”

“Me too, me too. But you did your best, Adora. And you saved the universe. You pulled it off, you fucking lunatic.”

Adora took a few shaky breaths and gulped. “ *We* pulled it off.”

“You know,” Catra started, unsure of how Adora would respond, “so far as the others are aware, we got down to the heart in time and the thing worked. But technically, it was kind of our super-hot young love that saved the universe,” she tried to joke, tilting her face up so she could see Adora’s expression. In the dim light from her eyes, she could see Adora smile weakly before another tear slid sideways over the bridge of her nose. “But we don’t have to talk about how it went down. Not until you’re ready.” Catra quickly squashed the pinch of disappointment when she felt at Adora’s little nod. She would have plenty of time to brag once the pain and fear had dulled some.

"It was so weird... I felt myself dying,” Adora whispered. Catra wiggled an arm beneath Adora so she could wrap it around her waist and hold her tighter. “Like, I could feel my body shutting

down, function by function. I could feel it all coming. I could feel the dying."

Catra snorted against the thrills of horror Adora's words sent spiraling through her and forced a small laugh, rubbing her back firmly. "I don't believe that your heart was *literally* giving out, and you kicked that bitch back into gear just so you could kiss a girl. Unbelievable. Even for you."

"So I could kiss *you* , stupid. Not just some girl."

Catra felt Adora bring a hand to her face, then felt her soft, warm lips press against hers. Her purr grew louder and she kissed her back, slow and sweet. Catra could feel the fresh tears on their cheeks and wiped them away as gently as she could between kisses as Adora slowly relaxed. When she dared to slowly run her hand down Adora's waist to her hip, where she retracted her claws and gave a cautious squeeze, Adora responded with a breathy sigh.

Catra's tail flicked and she smiled into their kiss when Adora's pinned hand found her own and gripped it. Their free hands roamed over one another, making detours into less polite areas with increasing boldness as their kiss heated and their breathing deepened. Catra thought of the hundreds, maybe thousands of times she'd caught her mind straying to daydreams and fantasies that started like this. She'd spent so many years of her youth longing for Adora, yearning to feel more of her, to savor, to *taste* .

She pulled Adora's lower lip between her teeth and bit lightly. Adora uttered a soft groan and swiped her tongue under Catra's upper lip, seeking entrance. She opened her mouth gladly and Adora's tongue immediately dove inside, plundering Catra's mouth until it felt like she'd tasted every corner. Then their tongues fell into massaging each other between their mouths, mindlessly wrestling as their excitement mounted. Catra's head started to swim and Adora's breathing deepened while they kissed, shifting their melded bodies where they lay.

When Catra finally indulged in gripping a handful of Adora's ass, she was rewarded with a soft moan. Adora moved her hips forward with Catra's tugging grasp and rolled them lightly against hers. Pressure began to build in Catra's lower stomach and she felt arousal start to gather between her legs.

Quite suddenly, she was out of patience. Catra had nearly a lifetime of repressed attraction to work out with Adora, and she didn't want to wait any longer. "Hey Adora? Are you sure you want this? With *me* ?" she asked in a breathless rush. "You know I'm trying to bang, right?"

"Oh yeah, for sure. Me too."

"Okay, cool cool cool. Just wanted to make sure you're down." Catra again cringed inwardly at her own awkward tone. She sounded like she was talking to an office coworker.

"I want you," Adora said. That corrected the mood right quick.

"I'll show you mine if you show me yours," Catra smirked.

Adora ignored her and reached to pull off her shirt. Catra quickly grasped her wrists and tugged upward gently, giving Adora the slack she needed should she want to pull free as Catra slowly drew her hands up above her head. She knew Adora, and she knew herself. She had ideas about how she was going to fuck her for the first time after years spent as enemies, and though it seemed appealing just then, she didn't want to let Adora go barging through the process like one of their training exercises. Adora's soft gasp was all the encouragement she needed.

She moved to straddle the other woman and raised up, feeling the blankets fall behind her, bearing Adora's clothed torso to the chill air. Catra watched her nipples harden beneath the thin fabric of her shirt and licked her lips slowly before she brought the fingertips of her free hand to Adora's stomach and watched it flutter at the gentle contact. "I've wanted you for so long. So fucking long."

"I've loved you for longer."

Catra stopped moving and gave Adora an exasperated look. "Can you not be that cute? It's making it hard to focus on being sexy over here."

"You can't *not* be sexy," Adora said, relaxing with her arms above her head still.

"Good point." Catra hooked her thumb under Adora's top and began dragging it upward. Adora arched her back so she could slide it up over her breasts, then up over her head. Catra twisted the garment around Adora's wrists so that she could get an easier hold on her before finally moving her gaze slowly back down her body, over the gold hair spread over the pillow around her, down the column of her neck and the grace of her collarbones and onward, feasting her eyes on Adora's exposed flesh.

Her body was thick with muscle, hardened by endless hours of fighting. The lines and planes of bulging muscle that shaped her was stirring enough, but the layer of softness that slid and quivered along Adora's frame was utterly entrancing. The pillowy little roll of flesh just beneath her navel, her breasts, larger than she remembered and supple now that they were free from constrictive combat gear... everything was just... *too* beautiful. Adora's breathing quickened as Catra ran her fingertips, smooth and firm, up along the center of Adora's breastbone.

"People shouldn't be allowed to be this hot. It's a public hazard, honestly." Catra lowered her mouth to kiss Adora's sternum, lightly. The other woman shifted beneath her and pressed her thighs together, causing Catra's pulse to leap. "So beautiful…" she repeated lazily.

"I thought you were gonna show me yours if I showed you mine," Adora said with a half-smirk. Catra felt a thrill of smugness at her breathless tone.

"I will if you behave," Catra teased. She let go of Adora's wrists, still wrapped in her stretchy top. "I think you could do with a little less of getting what you want when you want it." Adora scrunched her nose up at her but kept her hands obediently above her head, and Catra smirked back. "Plus it's fun to make you squirm." Catra pulled the nightgown off quickly, but not quick enough to keep Adora pinned down.

"Whatever you say," she whispered as she sat up and quickly threw her wrists over Catra's neck, pulling her in close so their bare torsos pressed up against each other, soft curves pressed up against soft curves, sliding over toned frames, betraying how frantically their hearts beat in their chests. The heady thrill of Adora's easy proclamation sent a hot flush through Catra's body. Catra could already tell they were going to have to spread her sexual agenda out. There was no way they'd be patient enough to get through much of it tonight.

As Adora pressed her mouth hungrily against hers, Catra licked along her lower lip. This time it was Adora who opened her mouth for Catra, and she made the most delicious sounds against Catra's kiss, little breaths and sighs and whimpers and moans, all combining to make Catra absolutely shitfaced with arousal. When Adora shifted beneath her to open her legs, making room for Catra's hips between them, an achingly familiar, intoxicating scent reached her. Catra dipped her head and breathed deeply, reveling in the scent of Adora's arousal before moving her hands up to her chest where she kneaded and caressed the burning, flushing skin, lost in the sighs she teased out of her. As Catra rolled her thumbs in gentle circles over Adora's pebbled up nipples, the other whined gratifyingly.

"Lower," Adora demanded in a strained whisper.

"What did I just say about waiting…" Catra began to taunt, but Adora cut her off.

"Fuck patience," Adora growled and Catra smiled. "We've got time for patience. Now touch me, Catra, *please…* " Catra silenced her

with another open-mouthed kiss and kept kissing her as she moved. She made quick work of Adora’s shorts, preferring to shred them with her claws rather than wrestle them off her. And then Adora was naked again, all cream and pink and gold, leaning back on her arms before her and panting. For a moment Catra was caught by the way her breasts moved over her ribcage with her heavy breaths, but she soon collected herself.

As she shifted them again to lay Adora gently down on her back, Adora left the shirt wrapped around her wrists and dug her fingers into Catra's short hair. When Catra felt fingers trail over the back of her neck, she stiffened. But to her great relief, Adora didn't mention it and simply adjusted her hold. Catra kissed her again and did her best to channel her passion into her tongue moving with Adora’s. She wanted to taste Adora’s hunger, to make sure it was as real as she needed it to be. She slid her palms down to drip Adora’s waist and curled her body slightly, pushing her own knees forward so that Adora's thighs spread wider on either side of her lower torso, both breathing roughly around their dueling tongues.

Catra had to admit that she had a good point about the time thing. She supposed she’d have plenty of chances to put Adora through her paces. But right now … Catra moved her hands slowly, trailing her fingers over Adora’s waist and flanks. She drew a clawed finger lazily down Adora's front, between her breasts and on down to bump over her navel, only to stop millimeters from where a small thatch of golden curls hid her arousal from view. Adora groaned, Catra leaned forward, retracted her claws again, and when she shifted her hand to run her fingers through the soft hair and cup Adora's sex firmly, Adora's groan became a bitten-back cry.

Catra propped herself up high enough for leverage, but close enough to maintain as much contact as possible, nipping at Adora’s jaw lightly when she arched up to press herself against her. Slowly, carefully, she began to move the fingers against Adora's wet outer lips in gentle circles, feeling her slick, swelling folds slide against each other from the outside. Their mouths

stayed glued together, but Catra kept her pressure light, ignoring the little involuntary movements Adora's hips made to draw her closer.

They kissed desperately until Catra pressed a finger forward, finally sliding into the dripping, searing folds. Adora jerked beneath her and leaned her head back, groaning from behind clenched teeth. Catra took the opportunity to move her lips down to her neck, kissing and licking her way from Adora's ear down her collarbone. She mouthed at Adora's shoulder, grazing her fangs over the skin there lightly and thrilling at Adora's small, pleading noises in the dark.

Catra couldn't allow herself to think, couldn't let her mind wander without being pulled back in time. So, she absorbed herself in everything Adora, doing everything she could to focus on how good Adora made her feel instead of on the shadows that waited at the corners of her mind. Right now was about them. For Catra, right now was about *Adora* ; her body, her sounds, her *fucking smell* … Catra was utterly obsessed with the creeping blushes that made Adora's rose petal skin glow like the moons. When she lifted her wet fingers to her mouth and began to lick them, Adora flushed deeper and bit her lip. A strong surge of lust gripped Catra, and she in turn gripped Adora, squeezing a thigh before slipping her hand back to Adora's core, pressing her two middle fingers forward to rub firm circles over her blooming sex. She slowly narrowed her circles, tighter and tighter, until the tip of her middle finger slowly circled her entrance, their lower pads braced against her clit.

"More," Adora gasped, pressing up against her.

Catra slowly pushed the finger forward, sliding it deep into Adora's passage in one fluid movement. Adora gasped raggedly and Catra groaned loudly as she leaned into her neck to breathe in her scent. "Fuck! Adora!" she ground out stupidly, slowly dragging her finger out before pushing it back in deeper, lowering her head as Adora's hips rolled against her. When she placed the tip of her

other middle finger against her opening, Adora nodded sharply, not bothering to talk.

She felt Adora stretch around her fingers, quivering as she opened her slowly, gently. She pulled her legs up higher, spreading her knees even wider for her.

"Catra," the other gasped in a pleading whimper. Catra growled fiercely and thrust deeper, pressing upward against Adora’s frontmost inner wall as she worked her fingers. “Don’t stop, please don’t stop,” she said. Catra looked up at her face, shining with a thin layer of perspiration. Her brow was pinched, her eyes were tight shut, and her ragged breath and beautiful gasps fell from parted, wet lips. Catra leaned upward, sliding her arm beneath her as she returned her fangs to Adora’s shoulder. She nipped lightly at the skin again and again between kissing, indulging in sucking on spots here and there until they glowed dark pink, delighting in the little marks that Adora would wear beneath her clothes the next day. Both the marks she was leaving on her shoulders, and many more marks she planned to leave elsewhere that night. Once the arm she braced herself with was beneath Adora’s shoulders, she wound her blonde hair between her fingers and gripped.

She pulled Adora’s head back by her hair, gently but firmly, and when she ran her tongue from Adora’s collar bone up her exposed neck, her lover shivered deliciously. She lingered there, face inches from Adora's, paying the utmost attention to her gorgeous reactions. She'd never studied anything harder.

Adora whined and Catra felt her hips jerk involuntarily, her body squirming beneath her as she worked. She gripped her hair harder and the other cried out softly, through a smile played across her open mouth. “Tell me, Adora,” Catra rasped, “say it again.” By the shaking in Adora’s legs, Catra could tell she was already surprisingly close to her first orgasm. She’d been revving up for a while, then.

“You’re the only one I want.” Adora’s words were rushed and pleading. “You’re the only one I’ve ever wanted, Catra. You’re the one that makes me wet, you’re the one I think about when…” she broke off into an exultant cry as Catra picked up the pace of her fingers.

“Look at me,” Catra commanded roughly, looking into Adora’s expression of close-eyed rapture. Her bright blue eyes snapped open and she made a face of supplication at Catra. “Let me watch you.” She tightened the arm beneath Adora and yanked her closer, holding her tight.

Adora maintained eye contact- beautiful, glowing blue eye contact- crying out and chanting her name. Catra was half-insane with lust, watching her move and beg, fueling all of Catra’s fantasies as they went.

“Holy shit I’m so glad we’re not trying to kill each other right now,” Adora babbled, her panting turning to gasping. “I mean, fighting you was honestly pretty hot, but-” her words cut off in a strangled moan when Catra thrust three fingers into her and kept moving her palm over Adoras swollen sex. She watched Adora's face and waited for her to relax into the new feeling before she started circling her clit lightly with her thumb. Adora gasped, moaned, and jerked in her tight hold. Catra settled into rubbing the little rough patch that marked the cluster of nerves nestled into the front of Adora's inner heat, letting the movement of her efforts move her thumb against Adora’s hypersensitive clit, holding on tight as she rode out her increasingly erratic motions.

Adora started losing control when Catra increased the pace of her fingers within her, and Catra rode on an exultant, triumphant high as she watched her come apart. “Come for me,” Catra whispered as smoothly as she could while panting herself. “Come for me, Adora.”

And she did so in spectacular fashion, crying out and trembling against Catra, coming hard into her hand. She slowed her rhythm but maintained movement until Adora started shying away from

the contact. When Catra had sufficiently collected herself, she let go of Adora’s hair and looked up at her, hoping she hadn’t been too forceful. Adora’s expression was one of rapture, however.

Catra smirked as she leaned back on her heels between Adora’s legs, sweeping her somewhat sweaty hair off her face and huffing as her breathing slowed. Adora winced slightly when she removed her fingers from inside her body, but her smile remained firmly in place.

“Oh wow...” she muttered faintly, eyes darkening again. “Catra, that was... you were... "

Catra again licked her fingers clean of Adora’s sweet essence, thoroughly enjoying the way she was staring. Then she leaned forward again and captured her mouth in a deep kiss, hoping Adora could taste herself on Catra’s lips. She only realized Adora had obediently kept her top wrapped around her wrists when she finally freed them and slid her arms around Catra’s middle.

Before Catra could say anything snarky or smooth, Adora shoved her back and flipped them both over, moving with impressive speed and strength. Quite suddenly, Catra was flat on her back and Adora had shoved both her knees between Catra’s thighs. She opened her mouth to crack a joke about Adora's eagerness, but the other used the opportunity to claim her lips and tongue in another fervid kiss. Catra heard her own purr stutter and grow louder, and felt Adora smile against her mouth. Then she felt her grip the backs of her thighs just above the knee.

"Waagh-" Catra made a strangled sound of alarm as Adora yanked upward, pulling her lower body up off the bed and scooting forward until only Catra’s upper back and shoulders were connected to the mattress. The rest of her was pulled up against Adora's front, and the other woman was grinning wickedly down at her from between the downy thighs she held wide. Catra gulped and tried to recover some bravado. "H- hey Adora," she giggled, sounding much more nervous than she'd hoped to.

Adora said nothing. Instead, Catra saw a muscle on her jaw clench as she smiled down at her, narrowing her eyes, dangerously. Then she bent down and *kissed* the puffy, dripping proof of Catra's lust.

Catra felt her ears pin back helplessly as she tucked her arms in and whimpered. " *Fuck me* ," she breathed in a shaking, barely audible murmur.

"On it!" Adora said gleefully, before diving in with gleeful abandon

* * * * *

At some point after dark, Entrapta slowly materialized in the gloom, riding toward him on Emily. He wasn't sure how many hours had passed, but night had fallen and with it, the pain had trickled back through his body. "Hordak!" she said happily, before seeing him more clearly. "Woah, have you not moved since I left you here? Are you okay?" she looked a little worried as she jumped off Emily and approached him.

"I," his voice crackled drily before he cleared his throat. "I am unhurt. I have merely been…" he looked for the right words, "taking account of things."

"Sounds heavy," Entrapta said before plunking down next to him. "Are you sure you want to tackle that right now?"

"Yes," he said. Emily came up close to him and nudged his leg. He reached out and patted her absently while he continued, "and you… Etheria is your home. You wish to build a future here, do you not?" he asked.

"Sure," she answered hesitantly. "Well, I want to do a ton of space travel, too, but yeah Etheria will always be home. I love this place." She smiled fondly. "I cut my teeth on First Ones tech, and

everything I learned on Beast Island… I can't imagine leaving that behind," She thought of something that made her face fall. "Do you want to leave? I understand if you do."

He shook his head, hating himself for being so selfish as to hope for a different answer. "No, I don't want to leave. I was deciding what to do now that I'm here." He had one option left, one last chance to protect her, and he was taking it.

"Oh!" Entrapta said brightly. She thought for a moment. "I know we got… awfully close last time we were partners," she said.

Emily gave a long, low whistle.

"Insolent bot," Hordak muttered, feeling his own face heat up at the memories her words had conjured.

"And I know things changed, and that we haven't been together in a long time- "

"I am *so* sorry I never came for you," Hordak interrupted, feeling a sudden and overwhelming urgency to make her understand. "I am so very, very sorry. You were left on that Island completely alone and-"

"Hey! Hey, it's okay!" She assured him in a soothing tone. "Catra explained what she did when she apologized to me. I know it wasn't your fault. It's okay!" Tears sprang to Hordak's eyes and Entrapta looked more alarmed than ever. "Hordak! What on Etheria is wrong?"

As she squished his face between her gloved hands and stared into his eyes, he calmed slightly. "I… I am overwhelmed. I apologize," he said, trying to recover his composure.

Entrapta seemed somewhat placated. "You don't need to apologize. It's been an overwhelming day," she said, releasing his face and watching him closely. "I just wanted to say... um... I'd like to be lab partners again, if you'd like that too. Or whatever you want to do is fine," she added, shyly.

Hordak nearly came to tears again before he answered. She was just so *good* . Too good to understand what had to happen. Instead of telling her his whole plan, he simply replied, "First, I'm going to officially surrender to the Princess Alliance."

Entrapta frowned. "Do we have to do that now?" she asked.

"What else would we do?" he asked, worrying about what it might look like if he avoided it, or what suspicions it might spawn around Entrapta's loyalties.

She slowly smirked before waggling her eyebrows at him.

"That's not what I meant," he corrected hurriedly. "I mean, you need to sleep and get back to your responsibilities, I need to… address mine as well."

"Can we have just a *little* bit of time together first?" she asked. He worried what she might have in mind but, as she held her hands behind her back and twisted back and forth on her feet, he couldn't bring herself to deny her request. At his uncertain nod, she suppressed a squeal. "Yay! Alright come on, I *have* to introduce you to Darla." He moved to follow her lead but gasped and snarled in pain. His left arm, shoulder, back and side hurt terribly.

"What is it?" Entrapta asked, at his side immediately.

"Prime's influence is wearing off," he said, readjusting his effort and standing up slowly. "He wasn't wearing armor but holding him out off the observation platform was still more than my body could handle, apparently."

Entrapta made a sympathetic noise as she began to lead him away from where he'd spent the last half of the day. "If it helps, you looked really cool while you did it." Of course, he would never admit that it did, in fact, help.

As they walked, something about the sound of Emily's uneven gait gave Hordak a creeping feeling of haunting familiarity. "How…

how long has it been? How long since…”

“It’s been a few months,” Entrapta answered. “I’m not exactly sure how long, actually. It’s been over a year since we were last together, though.” She looked up at him. Had her eyes always been such a fascinating shade of… red? Or pink. Maybe fuchsia. “Hordak?”

He slowed his steps so he could re-focus on their conversation. “Yes?” he rasped.

“I missed you. A lot.”

His hearts stuttered in his chest and he felt like he could have leapt out of his skin. For a moment he vividly recalled moping in his ruined Sanctum, gazing at her crystal and cursing himself endlessly for the damage he’d let her do. “I missed you, too.” Entrapta’s face lit up with another wide grin and her eyes sparkled. A whole new wave of feelings washed over him as she grabbed onto his arm again and gave it an affectionate squeeze.

As they walked on, Hordak kept glancing down at her. She was so beautiful. The most beautiful creature on Etheria, surely, and certainly the most intelligent being he’d ever met in the universe, which was saying something. The liveliness and passion she brought with her wherever she went was given readily, generously, to every person and thing she encountered, and it was more amazing to him than ever before.

“Entrapta,” he murmured. She looked up at him expectantly, and he realized he didn’t have anything to say to her. He’d just wanted to look at her face again. Her lavender eyebrows quirked as she peered at him, and he was struck with how the stars reflected in the shine on her eyes. “Tell me about your time in space, again. Please.” She beamed at him and sighed before launching back into the details. He drank in every word, trying to stretch these moments he had with her out as much as he possibly could.

Hordak assumed that Entrapta would return to her encampment, but to his surprise she insisted they spend the night on Darla. “Just in case,” she explained, cryptically. He had no reason to object, but he was as uneasy as ever as he meekly followed her toward the ancient ship, glancing around as they went, waiting for an attack by anyone from anywhere. He felt slightly better once they were on the ship and they were out of the open.

Entrapta chattered happily as she gave him an extensive tour of the ship, offering a double narrative to include technological inner workings that were hidden behind walls and within ductwork. He was deeply impressed with the thoroughness and intensity of her familiarity, though he wasn’t surprised. What did surprise him, however, was the physical proximity she maintained to him as they went. On top of the lack of space between their bodies, she was constantly reaching a tendril of hair out to brush down his arm or, nearly as often, her gloved hand to touch his elbow.

“And then these are the cabins,” she said as they rounded the last hall in the living quarters of the ship. He hesitated before following her but continued as she led him to the last door on the left. "I never actually slept here, but this is where I dumped my stuff. And it has a She-Ra sized bed." Hordak felt a feeble flutter in his chest.

"Where did you sleep?"

"Short naps in the walls, mostly." She gave the wall a few firm, affectionate pats and wore a devilish smirk. "Darla and I were a little preoccupied for full nights' rests."

He smiled despite himself. "Did I once hear Catra call you a Vent Gremlin, or am I imagining that?"

She smiled back. "That's a real memory." She tilted her head up at him, then rose up on her hair to face him on an even level as her expression slowly fell. "Hordak? Are you okay?" He had no answer for her. How could he? "Sorry, that was probably a dumb question, huh?"

"You don't have dumb questions."

She smiled again before holding out a hand for him to take if he wanted. He did, holding her small, gloved digits delicately between his own.

"We've all kind of been through it, these past few years," she chuckled, but he heard the threat of tears behind her tone.

Impulsively, he raised her hand to brush his lips briefly against the canvas-covered backs of her fingers. Her eyebrows raised up high, wrinkling up the skin on her forehead. "Thank you," he said, lowering it again but unwilling to let go, "for everything."

They stood in silence for a few moments, mere inches from one another. When Entrapta spoke again, it was in the quietest voice he'd yet heard her use. "I understand… I mean, it's totally okay if you'd rather have your own space after everything. But I missed you… so much. Would you stay here with me and Emily tonight? Before we have to face everything tomorrow?" Emily beeped quizzically and she peered at him with her brow furrowed in doubt, as if he could bring himself to deny her. He nodded and she led them to lay down together in silence.

He stifled a groan when his spine settled into a horizontal position for the first time in… he legitimately couldn't remember how long. He turned his head to look at her through the pain in his neck and shoulder. She was on her side, staring at him. So beautiful.

"You're my best friend, Hordak," she murmured softly. "It's going to be okay."

For once, he knew better than she did, but he couldn't tell her that. So, he pushed through the pain in his strained muscles to roll onto his good side to face her. They raised their hands and intertwined their fingers, even as the rest of their bodies stayed about a foot apart. "You're my best friend, too. The best friend a person could ever hope for."

She smiled and let her eyes close slowly. He waited until he knew she was asleep by her snoring and rolled back to face the ceiling. He had a lot of thinking to do before he faced the rebellion as their prisoner.

He settled into trying to string memories together, painstakingly reconstructing a chronology in his mind. It was going to be a long, painful night. And yet… Entrapta grunted and shuffled in her sleep and he felt a piece of her hair wind around his arm. Prime was gone. *Prime was gone* , and Hordak was left to his own fate. But for the first time, he had a chance to help Entrapta, instead of leeching off her talent. His fate may have been decided, but because of her and her friends, he knew what it was to face his fate as a free man. With a sad smile, Hordak realized he was experiencing the best night of his life.

* * * * *

Several hours and orgasms later, Catra lay with a sleeping Adora in her arms. Now that she'd worked some lust out of her system and Adora wasn't taking up her attention, she was wide-awake, mind wandering instead of drifting to sleep. She didn't want to, didn't like it, but she couldn't help but think of Hordak. After her time with Prime, she couldn't help wondering if she was really so different from him, after all. She'd hated him. *Oh, how she'd hated him*. But there had also been more. Grudging acknowledgement of one another, certainly. After all, they shared backgrounds of being discounted and tossed aside, and had both forced their way back up against the odds. But there was also… also a kind of toxic pseudo-support that they'd briefly shared. None of it had been good, but… it wasn't all bad, was it? Was there *anything* redeemable about what they'd achieved together? Their combined blood, sweat, and tears? Probably not, she thought, and she despised them both for it.

But here he was in Bright Moon. Just like her. Neither of them should be there. They were a stain on the princess' victory, and she didn't know what the hell she was going to do about it. Dark scenarios in which she and Hordak removed themselves from the equation swirled about her imagination, and she tried to push them away. Adora wouldn't have liked such ideas, and she knew she shouldn't either. She focused on her breathing like Perfuma had badgered her to try and buried her nose in Adora's hair. She stayed like that for what felt like a long time, trying to defy the memories and emotions that threatened to overwhelm her in the night.

It was difficult though. Even with Adora in her arms, the images that threatened her at the corners of her mind hearkened louder when she closed her eyes. She smelled Adora's hair and told herself firmly that there was no burning hint of antiseptic on the air. It was her and Adora, she kept telling herself firmly. Just her and Adora. Her and Adora...

Much to her annoyance, no sooner had she drifted off than Adora was shaking her by the shoulder, hissing her name. She cracked open an eye to see that it was still dark. "Fuck… *what* !?" she asked in a hoarse rasp, cranky and disoriented as her heart pounded with inexplicable adrenaline.

Adora looked stricken. "Catra… you were crying in your sleep." And just like that, she remembered the nightmare she'd slipped into.

"Oh."

A tear slid down Adora's face as she stared at Catra with horrified eyes. "You were begging someone to stop." Catra couldn't help a small gasp and shut her eyes tight against the dream that was now leaking into these waking moments. There was a long pause between them, neither knowing what to say next. "Do," Adora began hesitantly, "do you want to tell me about it?"

Catra shook her head and rubbed her eyes. Adora nodded in acknowledgement, and they lay back down, slowly.

“I love you,” Adora whispered. “I love you, and I want you.” She reached out and Catra forced herself to relax against the gentle feminine touch. “We’ve got each other, alright? And that’s never going to change again.”

“Promise?”

“Promise.”

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.
Cheers.

"Everything ends, it’s as natural to life as beginnings are."

Chapter Summary

> The princesses get ready to decide Hordak's fate before planning reconstruction. Hordak prepares himself to face his old enemies as their prisoner.

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves.
> Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Come dawn, Glimmer began gathering princesses, grabbing exhausted young women by the arm while they were still rubbing their eyes and yawning. As she did, she exchanged fragmentary conversation with them before dropping them off for tea or coffee and muffins. As they conversed, tired faces fell into deeper frowns and shaking heads, worry and sometimes a stray tear in their eyes. Etheria had been so thoroughly, so brutally damaged by so many years of war. Even though the environment was now restored, their world was still in shambles and their people were all reeling. The speed at which their celebratory spirit waned was testament to their exhaustion and war weariness.

Some kingdoms were far luckier than others. Plumeria, for one, was going to be a lifesaver. Mermista, on the other hand, would need a lot of help to maintain Salineas’ assets as she rebuilt. As the Princesses gathered and murmured with one another, Catra

stuck close to Adora, who was moving between clusters, mostly listening rather than talking. Catra listened too, and as she did the uneasy feeling inside of her grew until she was struggling to keep her ears from pinning back or simply running to hide from the beleaguered Etherians around her.

Eventually, Adora lead them to the edge of the room where she heaved a heavy sigh and looked into her eyes, brows furrowed. "And how about you?" she asked.

"What do you mean 'how about me'?" Catra replied.

"Like, where are you at in your head? How do you feel?"

Fuck she hated talking about feelings. But she loved Adora, and genuinely didn't want to shut her out. Although, she didn't know how to do things right, either. Catra took a slow, deep breath and considered for a moment. "I'm still so, so glad it's over, and that we both made it out. But…" she heaved another deep breath and let her face fall. "I'm worried about today's planning, I guess," she continued slowly. "Some part of me feels like the others are finally going to realize I shouldn't be here."

"They're not going to do that," Adora said earnestly. "And give it some time… we'll figure this out. Home is where you make it, right?"

Catra grabbed the back of her neck and pulled her into a brief kiss before touching her forehead to Adora's. "Home is where you are," she said before thinking. Then she stepped back and looked away. "To tell you the truth, Adora? I feel about as lost as I've ever been. I know I'm better off, it's just…" she searched for the right words, running a hand through her hair distractedly.

"You've had a mission to focus on for so long you're not sure where to go from here?" Adora offered.

"Yeah. That."

“Honestly, I feel lost, too.” Catra looked back at her and noticed that her brow was puckered and she looked uncertain. “But I think, at least for me, getting on the same page with the alliance as to how to help the people will make me feel better and help me focus. And remember Glimmer’s ideas about ex-bad guys spearheading reconstruction? At least that’s a welcome of some kind, right?” She managed a half-smile. “And… I mean, I am kind of excited.” Catra looked away again before she felt Adora’s hand slip into hers as she stepped closer. “I love you,” she whispered in her ear.

To her surprise, the idea of helping to rebuild Etheria was appealing to her. Catra liked the idea of doing something tangible to help combat the damage she’d contributed so heartily to. She wondered if it would be enough, though. For the princesses or for herself.

* * * * *

Hordak was alone with his thoughts as Entrapta slept fitfully beside him. He lay on his back now, feet hanging off the end of it, staring at the ceiling of the cabin and letting disjointed memory after disjointed memory wash over him. He thought of Entrapta on Beast Island, waking up alone and slowly realizing she’d been cast aside yet again. He marveled at her survival, which made him think of King Micah. Two conflicting memories floated back to him then, and he tried to disentangle them while his headache flared. He remembered standing on a battlefield as smoke cleared,

reveling in the unmatched thrill of victory as the defiant King Micah was forced to kneel at his feet, finally subdued. At the same time, he remembered kneeling at Prime's feet, terrified and feebly denying his many failures. He could remember mulling over the exciting new opportunities that came with victory when the king was brought into his throne room, bound hand and foot, to receive his sentence. A flash of terror swept the man's features when Hordak said the words 'Beast Island', but he hadn't lost his composure until Hordak had ordered that the rebellion be informed of their king's fate.

King Micah had turned desperate. "No! Please just say I was executed… please don't tell my daughter where I went, please don't tell my daughter!"

Hordak had held his hand up to stop his soldiers from dragging the king away, then descended the stairs toward him slowly. Prime had cupped his face gently- no, no that was the other memory- he had cupped Micah's face gently and said "Your sacrifice is recognized, King Micah. And do not fear for your wife and daughter, they are not forsaken. I will reach them eventually… inevitably," he finished with a smirk. He had stepped back and nodded for the king to be dragged away. The king had shouted back at him until he was knocked out with a stun baton.

In the present, Hordak raised his uninjured arm to press a hand over his eyes. King Micah had fought for his home, family, and people. Hordak had fought for a lie. He had done his utmost to summon Prime to *his friend's home* and had hurt the people she loved, all upon his own volition. In mere weeks, Prime's efforts in domination had quickly eclipsed what Hordak had achieved in decades of war and conquest, doing terrible damage to everything Entrapta and Etheria held dear. Hordak let his arm fall and kept staring at the ceiling, mind racing and memories swirling.

It was selfish, he knew, but he also couldn't help but think of his own wasted years. Every supposedly necessary sacrifice he'd made, all the numbing so that he could make swift and merciless decisions, the self-imposed bleak and stark lifestyle he'd led, the

isolation… every decision mocked him from his past now that he stood in the harsh light of truth. He thought of every sleepless night he'd spent, wracked with physical pain and obsessed with his own failures and guilt, terrified that he wouldn't be able to prove his devotion before his defect finally won out over his will to fight. Turning resolutely against his wasted life, he simply had to keep telling himself so that it might soak in: all of it was for nothing. It was all for nothing. It was all for nothing. It was all for nothing. It was all just a gigantic cosmic joke, and a cruel one at that.

Every pattern he'd ever read in Etherians, from their reasoning to their reactions… they were caused by real emotions and pain, as real as the pain he felt over Entrapta's assumed betrayal, and worse, his experience upon hearing of her true fate. And it was all for nothing.

When the sky outside was light, Entrapta began to stir. They hadn't gotten to Darla until quite late, and he hoped she'd sleep longer for her sake. Instead she spent a half hour murmuring and fidgeting in her sleep until she sighed, stretched, and looked up at him. Then she grimaced. "Hordak, you look terrible. Did you spend all night working yourself into a tizzy?"

"Never mind that," he dismissed, "do you think the princesses have assembled yet?"

"Emily, could you go keep an eye out and retrieve us once all the princesses are here? Glimmer messaged me and said she could get them herself this morning after a good night's sleep."

Emily beeped out of sleep mode and whistled in agreement before exiting the ship noisily.

"Hordak, you seriously need to rest, you do not look well," Entrapta said, lifting up one of his eyelids.

"I did try to rest," he admitted, "but I'm afraid my mind would not quiet."

“Hmm,” she huffed in disapproval.

He knew he was likely to raise her suspicion, but he’d left so much unsaid for so long, he was urgently compelled to talk to her now; to sooth her, make her understand. “Entrapta, I feel… so fortunate to have reunited with you. I’m sorry I wasted so much of our friendship, so much of our time. Happy endings are always temporary, but for a moment, we got ours. It’s more than I ever thought I’d have.”

“What do you mean ‘happy endings are temporary’? What’s temporary about ours?”

“Entrapta,” a physical pain was manifesting throughout his gut as he struggled for words. “No matter how many victories and close calls, no matter how much it seems like fate is involved, we're all part of a sad ending eventually.” He’d heard similar words from Prime’s own lips. He’d been speaking of his own victims and he hadn’t been wrong. Entrapta’s face had fallen, and she blinked at his shoulder with her head cocked, listening patiently. “There will come a day that only one of us will be alive to see. And that's alright. Everything ends, it’s as natural to life as beginnings are. I’m so very glad to have found you… that you found me...”

“You’re sounding very ominous, Hordak. Are you being dramatic, or should I be worried?”

He had to steel himself to maintain composure. “I know I have no right to make demands of you, but I have a request.”

“Hordak, you’re starting to scare me,” she said in a low voice, her eyes wide and her forehead drawn.

“I wish for you to try to learn what became of Imp. I can only hope he survived and, if he did, please make sure he is cared for. He’s a beastly little thing, but- ”

Entrapta pressed a tendril of hair against his mouth to silence him. “Hordak, you can do that yourself. Why do you sound so…

banal?" She narrowed her eyes at him. "What do you think the princesses are going to do to you?"

"Considering what I've done," he responded once she freed his mouth, "they are left with few options." He heard Prime's velvet whisper in his ear; ` *the wages of sin...*'

"Uh huh," she scowled, "Hordak, don't forget who you're dealing with. They're good people who believe in making a better world. They're not going to hurt you like Prime did. I'm not really sure what they're going to do," she conceded, tilting her head again and looking away before snapping her attention back to him, "but they won't hurt you, I promise."

She didn't understand, but he didn't want to waste time trying to convince her to see things his way. Instead, he groaned as he struggled to a sitting position and Entrapta followed suit. His injured arm, shoulder, and side had stiffened and swollen beneath Prime's Armor, and they hurt terribly. Even at a standstill the ache was severe enough to be distracting.

"You're not going to get thrown away again," Entrapta said softly as she rested a section of hair on his shoulder.

"You have the most generous heart I have ever known," he said, hoping she wouldn't consider how few people he'd ever gotten to know.

She smiled awkwardly as she got up and stretched again. She hadn't finished yawning when they heard Emily board the ship then come beeping and whistling and stomping down the hall. "That's our cue," Entrapta said brightly.

Hordak stood with another pained grunt and slowly straightened his arm out at his side. So long as he didn't move anything other than his legs, he would be able to ignore the pain for quite some time. He followed Entrapta off the ship, bullying his joints back into motion as they went.

As Entrapta remained uncharacteristically quiet, Hordak drilled himself on the coming ordeal. He knew what to do; after all, he'd been on the receiving end of the process enough times in the past to know what the princesses needed to see from him. Complete submission. Supplication. Admission of all wrongdoing. He must not disagree. He must not make excuses. And he must not let them see him sweat. If he could. He would try, anyway, regardless of his record of emotional composure.

He hadn’t noticed because of the tree cover and the dark, but Darla was actually very close to the palace of Bright Moon. In just a few minutes they both stood at the bottom of the outdoor staircase that led to the palace entrance. At the top stood all the princesses of the alliance, with Adora and the Queen standing at the front. Judging by the intensity of their staring, Adora had informed them of his identity.

He looked at Entrapta, unsure and nervous. She smiled and said, “don’t forget to breathe,” with a wink. He nodded, smiled back, then climbed the stairs as the princesses watched him warily. When he stepped onto the landing, he paused for a moment and drew himself up as straight as he could, lifting his chin.

“What do you want?” the queen asked.

“I am Hordak, former commander of the Etherian Horde, and I hereby surrender to the Princess Alliance,” he said in a loud, clear voice.

Apparently, this hadn’t been what they expected. They merely stood and blinked at him for several strained seconds, and he saw Entrapta shrug from the corner of his eye. He lifted a brow, unsure of what to do.

“Alright, well,” the queen finally answered, deflating slightly before turning back to the others. “We might as well be formal about it. Everybody inside.” Hordak looked at Entrapta in confusion, but she shrugged again and ushered him in after the princesses.

* * * * *

As the princesses gathered for muffins and chit chat, they'd begun to realize the scale of disruption across Etheria. Without exception, every one of them was overwhelmed by the depth of their peoples' need, if still flush with success over Horde Prime. Glimmer had been worried that this brutal reality check would make them more eager to punish Hordak and other ex-Horde, but they surprised her. After having been through so much, most of the princesses were of a softer disposition toward Hordak than she had expected. Many of them were already dealing with disaffected clones in their home kingdoms and had questions about Hordak of their own. Those princesses whose kingdoms had been most affected by the Etherian Horde's last push after the portal incident had been the most hardened, but even they wanted more information before they formed their opinions.

Once guards had led Hordak to the holding cell and Glimmer had granted permission to Entrapta and Wrong Hordak to follow him there, the princesses turned to one another.

They all turned at the sound of Entrapta's voice. "Catra?"

Catra looked surprised but answered, "Yeah?"

"Can I ask for a favor real quick?"

Catra cocked her head in confusion for a moment before realization dawned on her face and she groaned, grimacing in dread. "Oh no," she whined.

"You owe her a lot more than a favor," Adora reminded her.

"Yeah, yeah, I'm going," Catra said as she broke from the group to speak with Entrapta. It only took a few seconds, and as Catra returned to the group, she called back over her shoulder at the

pigtailed princess, who was already on her way back down the hall. “I’ll do what I can, but I’m not making any promises,” she shouted.

“Thank you!” came Entrapta’s high-pitched reply.

She stopped when she realized everyone was staring at her. After a moment, she shook herself and smoothed her hair back. “Whatever. What are we talking about?”

Mermista growled and rolled her eyes. “Nothing. Are we ready to do this?”

“Ready as I’ll ever be,” said Glimmer. “Obviously Etheria is still in crisis and we don’t have time for a full-blown trial. So, for the last time, is everybody okay with moving forward with today as planned?” She waited for rebuttal, and upon hearing none she continued. “Alright then. Dad and Bow should have changed out the table by now- everybody to the War Room.”

* * * * *

When the guard called Entrapta, Wrong Hordak, and himself from the sumptuous room he’d been assured was a holding cell, he rose without showing pain. He cracked his neck and moved his left arm slowly. Pain blossomed from his flank up through his neck and out to his fingertips. As ever, he ignored it while he slowly straightened his shoulders and arms, palmed Entrapta’s crystal in his good hand, then moved his hands behind his back. He still had one last job to do, and he leaned into the old refuges of decorum and aloofness to prepare for the coming ordeal.

He walked the halls of the palace behind Entrapta and Wrong Hordak with his hands at his sides and his chin up, reminding himself over and over again what he was there to do. He thought of Entrapta’s work, of Adora’s potential, Catra’s tenacity, and the

terror of his fellow clones. He thought of Imp, and he desperately hoped that the little gremlin was alive and well. He thought of all that they would accomplish together, and his chest loosened up enough for him to take a breath. When the guard opened the door to the War Room, his shoulders were squared, his hands were lightly clasped at the small of his back, and he'd schooled his expression into one of haughty calm.

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.
Cheers.

“Every time you open your mouth, it's depressing.”

Chapter Summary

Hordak's hearing starts and the princesses examine his many, many, many heinous deeds.

Chapter Notes

Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves.
Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He walked forward into a large room full of people and Adora’s talking horse, who was sitting upon a pile of splintered wood that seemed to have been furniture at one point. The princesses were all gathered around a row of tables that were arranged in almost a full circle, leaving a space just in front of the door, presumably for guest experts to come and council them. Behind them were arranged their various entourages. His steps faltered for just a moment when he saw a scene from one of his purification rituals superimposed over the present, a sea of green eyes staring from all around him. Then he blinked hard and was back at Bright Moon. He forced himself to keep walking.

“ *You look terrible* ,” Catra hissed at him in a stage whisper, but he ignored her as he found his place in the center of the room, squaring his shoulders and glaring ahead.

Everyone in the room regarded him with serious faces, some nervous, others angry or else guarded. He was familiar with all the princesses and much of their fellows seated and standing behind them. He'd made it his business to become familiar with all his enemies. Several long seconds passed without sound after Hordak had come to stand before the princesses and for a moment, he thought he could hear a distant chant of ` *cast out the shadows.* ' But... no. Of course he was imagining it. Finally, the Queen broke the tension in the room.

Glimmer cleared her throat and every face turned toward her. "Hordak, formerly Lord Hordak, commander of the Etherian Horde. We've summoned you to appear before the Alliance today to answer our questions and accept our decisions regarding your place on Etheria. I'm going to cast a truth spell on you, and all members of the Alliance are welcome to ask and say whatever they want to. Do you understand?"

He hesitated but nodded. He'd rather eat broken glass than have his feelings and secrets forcibly laid bare again, but he'd forfeited any right to privacy upon his surrender. Without further ado, the Queen formed a truth spell in the air in front of her and sent it whooshing through him. He braced himself with a set jaw, but felt nothing as the spell passed through his body.

Queen Glimmer glanced around at the other princesses, betraying uncertainty for the first time. "Okay," she began slowly, "I guess we'll start at the beginning?" Catra rolled her eyes but Adora and the archer Bow nodded encouragingly. "Why did you come to Etheria more than 25 years ago?"

Now Hordak felt the spell. He scrambled to formulate his words on his own terms, but he was compelled to answer quickly and openly. "I was pulled through some kind of portal during battle," he said, and was able to stop there.

"So it was an accident?" the Queen asked. Several skeptical eyebrows raised within view, and he could tell it wasn't the answer they were expecting.

“All I am certain of is that I crashed in King Scorpio’s territory with no idea how I’d gotten there or how to return.” He clenched his teeth to try and stop talking as soon as he physically could.

“So you had no idea why that happened? None at all?” This time it was Adora who spoke, looking disappointed.

“I… for a time I thought, perhaps, it was a test of faith, though I couldn’t imagine the logic behind such an option." He thought he could sense Wrong Hordak nodding just behind his periphery. "Then I thought, perhaps, Prime had sentenced me to death by solitude.”

“Death by solitude?” Princess Mermista raised a disdainful brow.

“The most feared punishment among clones,” Wrong Hordak confirmed soberly.

“Correct,” confirmed Hordak. “But, sitting and waiting for death was... unacceptable to me." He grunted slightly, trying to focus on the bare facts in his memories, rather than the appalling state he'd been in. "For quite some time, I thought it was all part of his ephemeral plan. Eventually I realized my theories didn't matter, because the only appropriate course of action was to remain faithful and try to find my way ho- my way back to Prime.”

“Sooo,” Princess Scorpia spoke up. “Why’d you join Granddad and wage his war against everybody?”

"I believed that regardless of *how* I’d become marooned, my priority was to return to Prime’s service. In my Supreme arrogance and foolishness, I hoped to return to my privileged rank at his side. In order to do so, I needed access to resources that were not available to me otherwise. King Scorpio and I had different goals, but military expansion served both of our interests.”

“Um,” said Princess Perfuma. Hordak recognized her. She was the one *with the war chimes* . He resisted the urge to curl his lip at the thought. “Those raiding parties you used to send out…” she trailed off.”

“You manipulated your soldiers into terrorizing civilians by telling them they were attacking rebel strongholds rather than villages. Do you have any excuse for that?” Adora asked.

“None whatsoever,” he said. “Then again, I never truly saw Etherians as people. Rather, I saw you all as… lesser beings of some kind. I always did, until very recently. My understanding of you existed completely within the context of my own origin. I was made in the image of the exalted one, you were... I didn't know or care what you were made of. I was able to justify terrible mistreatment because I couldn’t imagine it and never tried."

The reactions he saw in the faces around him varied widely. Some, like Princess Mermista, looked livid. Others looked nonplussed or seemed to be thinking hard. Adora, for some reason, looked guilty. There was still more answers he was compelled to give, however, so he continued talking as he watched them. “My reasoning for the offensive action was that search-and-destroy missions in civilian settlements served many useful purposes. Most importantly, they kept insurgents on their toes. Furthermore, they helped demoralize rebels and civilians alike, kept my fighters active and *competitive* with one another, kept them numb to the violence they did, and it prevented the emergence of any kind of live-and-let-live habits.”

He opened his mouth to continue, but was relieved to find he could stop there. In the ensuing pause, he suddenly remembered Imp playing a recording of a soldier playfully chanting ‘ours is not to question why, ours is but to do and die.’ It wasn’t something he’d taught them, he absolutely did not *do* rhymes. But he’d been relieved that his indoctrination program was working on at least one of his troops. He knew too well from personal experience they'd be better off not thinking too hard about their duties.

Adora, Catra, and Scorpia all exchanged mournful looks that made his stomach sink.

“And we’re supposed to believe that you’ve changed? What, you’re good now?” Mermista asked in a caustic tone.

“No. I am the same man that did those things, and I have always been a comparatively bad person.” Mermista sneered at him, though there was puzzlement on her brow. “It wasn’t until I experienced more aspects of life on Etheria that I developed any kind of sympathy or doubt, and it was a reluctant and grudging development. I did everything I could to resist it.” His tone was haughty and his face placid still. He desperately hoped he’d be able to maintain it. He might have to subjugate himself to old enemies, but he would retain as much dignity as he could as he did so. He knew he had no right to dignity, but he couldn’t bring himself to grovel. Not after all that time on the floor, sobbing half-explanations and apologies and begging for mercy.

“Back when you came through the portal,” began a man with a heart on his jacket that Hordak did not recognize. He was sure, however, that he could detect the remnants of military bearing in the man. “If you were high ranking, why were you on the battlefield?”

Hordak bared his teeth at the floor and suppressed a growl. “I made mistakes and lost Prime’s favor. He had deemed me unworthy and decided to dispose of me. However,” he took a slow breath and did his best to maintain his disciplined affect, “on this particular occasion, he chose to show mercy. He rewarded my loyalty with a chance to die in his service.” Some whispering swept around the room, but he kept his gaze lowered. He scoffed at himself lightly before muttering “I couldn’t even do that right.”

“So merciful…” Catra muttered. He ignored her.

Princess Mermista cut in. “So you were cut off from the hive mind when you got to Etheria, right?” she asked with narrowed eyes.

“Yes.”

“Then why did you want to go back? You were free, so why didn’t you just chill instead of trying to destroy the entire planet?” He could tell she was still fuming.

“I could not imagine a future without Prime, much less one spent amongst hostile Natives. I decided early on to conquer Etheria and give it to Prime. I hoped that if I proved I could still conquer worlds for him, I might demonstrate my worth and regain a life of service.”

“Hostile Natives?” Glimmer asked.

“The first Etherians I encountered were... less than friendly, though I can hardly blame them for being repelled. I had, after all, destroyed an entire irrigation pond and field of crops with part of an alien spaceship, and was feeling less than friendly myself at the time.” Pain began to radiate outward from his spine and he shifted on his feet.

“At the time?” Catra asked pointedly.

He sighed. “All the time,” he corrected. “At least until... until somebody decided to be my friend despite my appalling views and behavior.” He pressed his mouth into a tight line as he saw Catra slowly smirk.

“But what about the people?” This time it was Princess Perfuma who spoke. “What about all the people you were hurting with the war?”

The regret building in his stomach churned and he grimaced. “First, I’ll repeat that I didn’t see Etherians as people. I imagined that you were simple, base creatures. Primitive by nature and by choice. I saw your rebellion as the tantrums of rebellious children, and believed that whatever suffering I inflicted in the process of bringing Etheria to Prime’s light was greatly outweighed by the larger benefits of my goal. Creatures who are so primitive as to let their petty differences prevent them from maintaining order for the greater good are… *were* , I believed, in need of a strong hand to guide them."

He felt himself grow heavier as the damning words left his mouth, and he had to split his attention to keep his ears from falling as he

continued. "Prime's empire was one of unparalleled greatness, and I agreed that it was our *responsibility* to our fellow inhabitants of the universe to provide worlds with access to a better future, instead of leaving them to be victimized by their own misguided choices. I believed the planets we inducted were far better off under Prime than exposed to intergalactic predators." He heaved a sigh that burned through his back. "Those who suffered were purified by their pain, and their misguided sacrifice would be redeemed by the grace of Prime. I believed he would bless you with order and everlasting peace, or else purify you with light before returning you to your eternal night." Hordak was utterly overwhelmed by the words coming out of him. Not only was he talking more about himself than he ever had in his life, but he was saying things he'd never actually thought about nor consciously decided. His brain could barely keep up with his own mouth.

"But how could you believe such insane nonsense and believe it with all your heart and soul?" Princess Mermista was clearly struggling to stay calm. "How could you accept such far-fetched crap when so much evidence was heaped in your lap to prove otherwise? How could you be so far gone that facts don't matter?" She curled the hands on the table before her into tight fists. "You're a scientist! Facts should matter to you! How could you be so blind? How could you be so deluded!?"

"No matter how much you loved Prime," Glimmer cut in, her own frustration apparent, "how could you tear families apart and level villages and think it was all worth it? He threw you away! How could you still want to deliver us to him like… like some kind of offering?"

"Are you asking me to explain the worldview that made it seem just and sensible?" Hordak asked for clarification, wishing he could just stop talking.

"Yeah, if you can, sure."

He took a deep breath before plunging into words he couldn't anticipate before saying them. "In the natural order of things, lower beasts bow to higher beings. This is… I believed it was the most natural and logical path to peace… the universe's best hope against chaos and darkness. This was the salvation that Prime offered." He swallowed, shifting his eyes to stare at the table in front of the queen. "This was the way for planets to avoid the ravages of entropy- to become one with Prime's light by joining his eternal empire. It was an honor to participate in this sacred civilizing mission. To join the empire is- was, I believed- the best thing any individual could ever do for themselves." To his profound revulsion, he had to repress a wistful smile at the memory of a time when he had been secure and at peace in his worldview. "To become part of the glorious imperial machine was to elevate oneself from the isolation of individuality, the burden of memory, up into the realm of holy selflessness- the purest form of freedom." He'd been squinting at the table, but as he lifted his eyes again and saw that everyone in the room looked deeply disgusted. He felt his ears draw back in frustrated shame and tried to relax his expression again. "I remind you that I am under the influence of a truth spell," he ground out, trying not to betray nervousness. "If you do not like my honesty, the fault is your own."

"No, no… I just," Queen Glimmer pulled a face and shook her head, "there's a lot to unpack with that one. Wow."

Princess Mermista let her mouth drop open as she glared. She tried to speak once, growled as she pressed her fingers to both temples, then tried again. "So you're saying," she said slowly, "that you spent decades - *decades* - waging global war, all to impress one gigantic jerk who blew you off?"

He quirked his brow. "I suppose so, yes."

She let her head thunk gracelessly onto the table and groaned long and loud. "You're *kidding* me. That is so… sooo…" she lifted her head and her face was screwed up in churning emotion,

"*pathetic. That's so pathetic*." She lapsed into an enraged glare that she turned back on him.

"Indeed," he was forced to agree with a curled lip.

"So if you were just doing your duty, why'd you end up as such an angry, vengeful person?" Adora asked. "Why were you so hateful?"

Hordak didn't know. He'd never thought about it. He kept talking anyway. "I was bitter over my failures, over my confusion, and over my situation. I was… deteriorating quickly." He drew a small, right breath, resisting the urge to mention the growing panic that had accompanied his advancing infirmity. So he was relieved that instead, he was able to try and focus on just how and why he'd changed so much in those early years. "I had to adapt my martial techniques from those designed for an army in a hivemind, to techniques that might work on a rabble of individuals whose only commonalities are their *fear* of suffering and their *devotion* to one another. Eventually I learned to convince my forces that I was their best bet against pain and suffering, and cultivated their loyalty to each other as well as myself so they wouldn't stop fighting. It's the best I ever managed, and it was a highly imperfect system. I'm afraid my manners were one of the first things to be sacrificed in the name of efficiency." He heard the man with a heart on his jacket snort to himself. He thought he might have caught the faintest twitch in the corner of the Queen's mouth as well.

"I don't know if that's an excuse for the kind of rage you used to stomp around with," said Catra with a raised brow. "Or are you really just that much of an asshole?" Her gaze was intense, and he had the distinct impression that she wasn't just trying to shame him.

Compelled to answer, he began hesitantly. "I… I was angry before I was demoted, and I was angry when it happened, and… I had been powerless to stop any of it. Completely and utterly powerless." He huffed at the floor and allowed a grim smile to

himself. “That time... it was... quite difficult. My despair and fear were incapacitating. It took some time, but I eventually learned to fight back with rage. It was the only emotion that didn’t feel like weakness. Even when the sorrow had numbed and the fear subsided, rage felt better than emptiness. Despair is crippling, but anger can be channeled into productive action.” Hordak longed to stop talking, willed himself to with all his might. “Another advantage to maintaining an active, if cold state of rage was that it also conveyed a constant threat of violence, which inspired enough fear that I was able to control the people around me. Well,” he paused, thinking of Entrapta, “except for the ones who weren't afraid.” Catra stared at him with a slightly open mouth and furrowed brow, obviously perturbed by his explanation.

“And you did it all so you could prove to Prime you were… capable?” Princess Perfuma asked.

“To prove that I could still be his general. That I could still execute the duties he needed me to, even though I'd lost the beauty he'd given me.” Hordak's stomach swooped in terror but only a few confused glances were exchanged.

“Do you know why he was so angry when he retrieved you?” Queen Glimmer asked.

“That is my fault as well...” He shook his head in abject bitterness. “So very foolish. I should have known. Destruction under Prime's direction is... *was* unfortunate, but necessary to our ultimately benevolent mission. What I did was not under his direction. I was acting upon my own free will, which meant that every improvisation and adaptation I made was blasphemy of the highest order. I transformed myself, of my own free will, into an..." he stalled, hoping he could stop there.

“An abomination,” Catra finished for him.

“Correct.”

When several princesses shot Catra disapproving glances instead of him, she held her hands up in defense. “Prime’s words, not mine.”

“Okay now, alright,” Princess Scorpia interjected with a nervous laugh. “So you were trying to conquer an entire planet. That’s bad, but…” she seemed to search for the right words, “it’s not like, *Prime-bad* , right?”

“What about manipulating Entrapta into betraying us for the Horde?” Princess Spinnerella asked. “Why did you make her think we abandoned her?”

He felt suddenly defensive at the suggestion he’d manipulated Entrapta. “How was I to know what you had assumed? I thought you were just stupid!” He caught himself and pressed the fist with Entrapta’s crystal in it against his mouth.

“Actually, that’s my bad,” Catra interrupted sheepishly. When she again received a round of attention she quailed slightly. “Hey. This party is supposed to be about truth, right? I’m just trying to keep up my end of things.”

“Counterpoint,” Entrapta broke in, and Hordak twisted through firey pain with a small wince to catch her from the corner of his eye, “it’s neither of your bads. Catra said that the alliance left me behind and hadn't come back to look for me. She also said that if I joined the horde, I wouldn't have to pretend to be something I'm not, like the princesses wanted me to. She was correct on both counts."

“But we didn’t mean to leave you behind!” Adora insisted, upset and defensive.

“That is also true,” Entrapta answered calmly. “All of it is true.” She smiled at the room around her, determinedly radiant as ever. Hordak could practically feel her warmth shining off the back of him as he listened. “If I may point out the obvious for the sake of conversation: you all keep trying to break what happened down

into archetypal patterns; trying to assign a victim and a villain and a right answer that was intentionally ignored. Hordak has the same problem with black and white thinking," she said warmly, "and I understand the impulse toward the comforting theory that a right answer even exists, but that's just not how things work out in practice."

"She's right." This time it was Princess Perfuma who addressed the room. "I've been thinking a lot about the same thing. I used to believe I knew what was important, and specifically friendship was like, *my thing* ." She laughed nervously again. "But after everything with Entrapta, learning about the Scorpion kingdom's history, getting to know Scorpia and Glimmer and Wrong Hordak and everything... people are just… so very *complex* ." She smiled and laced her fingers together in front of her. "There's certainly a lot of wrong ways to do things, but I don't think anybody's figured out a right way yet. Prime claimed he had, but we see how that went for everyone. Now I think that living well is more about learning from each other as we go, even if that means a lot of listening past differences, and a lot of forgiving each other for being wrong."

A lengthy silence passed before Princess Spinnerella spoke again. "Okay… what about the child-soldiers?"

Hordak cocked his head, surprised by this particular point. "Which ones? Those born of horde soldiers? Or those who were inducted into military service?"

"Let's start with the latter," Netossa said, crossing her arms and glaring.

Hordak answered easily, this time. "Children often fall by the wayside during wartime evacuations- it is unfortunate, but to be expected during periods of upheaval. While I did not spend our resources on tracking down their original families, it didn't make sense to abandon unsupervised children in occupied areas, especially as they were young enough to be inculcated in horde

ideology and eventually graduate into service- which I believed was the most noble of callings.”

“But why did you have to train them all to be weapons from birth? The ones who were born into it *and* the ones you stole," Princess Netossa demanded.

He was unsure of how to answer, but explained the obvious anyway. “Statistics all indicate that the earlier they started training in combat skills, the greater their chances of survival once they entered active duty, which wasn’t allowed until late adolescence.” He looked at Princess Frosta pointedly, who scowled at him.

“She means you stole our childhoods,” Catra explained dully.

“I don’t understand,” he said. “I remember when you were a child.” He huffed and quirked the corner of his mouth. “You were a problem then, too.” Catra laughed in obvious self-satisfaction.

“Like… the time in our lives when we were supposed to be kids. We never got to do kid stuff.” Adora tried to clarify.

“Ah yes, Shadow Weaver had things to say about Etherian young needing specialized care for nearly *two decades* before they became anything other than a drain on resources,” he said, trying to keep his voice free of disdain.

“You took Shadow Weaver’s advice?” King Micah asked with a scowl.

“Who else would I take advice from?” he asked.

“You're talking like you were never a child,” Glimmer said.

“I wasn't.”

“What?” Spinnerella asked.

“I mean,” he amended, “I was certainly in existence for a time before I reached physical maturity, but I wasn't very aware of the

fact. I spent my entire development in a vitrine. My mind was purposed for conquest and my body was activated into development via electrical currents."

Catra shook her head. "Every time you open your mouth, it's depressing."

"Wait, so everything you know about kids, you learned from Shadow Weaver?" Netossa asked.

"Etherian children, yes."

"Wow, that explains a lot," Catra said, still shaking her head.

"But still, how could you put so much responsibility on teenagers?" Castaspella asked earnestly.

"Because teenagers can still be extremely useful, as is documented in Etherian history. Frosta, as example, was eight years old when she took the throne, and that isn't at all anomalous among Etherian royalty," Hordak stated simply, hoping it was enough to explain why children might be saddled with adult responsibility. Frosta folded her arms and glared at him, trying to decide whether or not to be offended.

"Royalty are responsible for seeing their people thrive, not choosing which ones die," said the queen, angrily.

"Do you suggest that royals never have to prioritize some lives over others? I remind you that war existed here before I ever came to Etheria," he said, starting to feel defensive again.

"Hang on… Hordak, how many men were in your first command?" Bow interjected.

He couldn't remember which planet or which command had provided his first experience in conquest, but certainly… "Several thousand at least."

Bow nodded. “Uh, huh. And how old were you when you received that command?”

“Counting the day I gained consciousness as an approximation to the Etherian notion of 'birth'... About six months.”

“There it is,” Bow said as the room broke out in murmurs.

“That’s different,” Hordak replied, scowling.

“Is it?” Queen Glimmer asked with a sympathetic look.

“I was programmed with all the information a general…”

“Do you hear yourself?” Catra interrupted. “*Programmed.*”

“What advantage or responsibility comes with age if not the wisdom of experience?” Lance said with a frown.

“Yeah, and what access did you have to that stuff?” said Adora.

Princess Perfuma spoke up with a despairing look. “Your body and mind were full grown, but your soul was just a little baby.”

“Gross,” said Catra.

“Okay,” Princess Mermista said, heaving a giant sigh, “so you’ve said a bunch of super depressing stuff, but I have yet to hear a single redeeming quality. So tell us, do you have *any* of those?”

This answer was easy, though he still hated to say it out loud. “No. I have proven useless in every meaningful way.” He heard Entrapta make a frustrated sound behind him.

“Entrapta, what on earth did you ever see in this guy?” Mermista asked, and Hordak was surprised to hear a note of genuine curiosity in her tone.

Hordak spun on his heel as he heard Entrapta’s chair scoot on the floor. She lifted her mask and rose up on her hair so she could be seen better. “Actually, I based my decisions on quite a number of

observations.” As usual, she was bright and matter-of-fact, well and above the dim atmosphere that had settled over the room. Even as he admired her indelible character, he scowled in confusion. What could she *possibly* have to say?

“Reeeally.” At least Princess Mermista’s incredulous skepticism made sense.

“Really!” Entrapta grinned and launched into explanation mode. “Honestly, once I’d seen Imp’s little boots and suspenders, I knew Hordak couldn’t be all bad.”

“Imp?” Frosta asked, but nobody answered.

Entrapta happily rambled on. “Hordak didn’t want me around at the beginning, and Catra tried to warn me away, but you all know how good I am at listening to advice." She snorted and giggled, and Hordak felt one of his lower eyelids twitch. "Anyway, at first I just wanted access to his tech. Then I mostly wanted his data on space and other worlds. But! I was also fascinated by the inner workings of this intergalactic system he called Prime’s Empire, and of course the idea of connecting Etheria with countless other planets full of countless other peoples with countless other languages and measurement systems and approaches to the cosmos and THE TECH! Oh my goodness the tech! And of course, the princess system isn’t exactly the *most* efficient form of rule, and I knew you guys were afraid of change, but I figured once the transition had occurred, you’d see the advantages of being brought out of isolation. I mean, how lonely and limiting was it to be the only ones in Despondos without any stars or neighbors or *anything*? Of course, I was wrong, like woah, like so wrong *never been more wrong*, although I’m still just as excited for Etheria to be connected to the rest of the universe again. The stars alone- “

“Entrapta.” Catra interrupted loudly.

Entrapta blinked a few times before brightening and launching back into speech. “Oh right! What I saw in Hordak! Anyway, as it happened, we got along quite well once he got over his whole

solitude thing." She switched positions in mid-air, hair forming a seat that she rested upon cross-legged. "After he got to know me a little bit, he never made me feel like an outsider, he always treated me with fairness and listened to what I had to say even if he was grumpy and dramatic about it sometimes, and he respected that I knew what I was doing and trusted me even when I couldn't quite explain all my ideas before showing him. Plus, it's *super* helpful to have a partner who knows their way around a lab."

"Entrapta," the Queen cut in, "that's all… fine. But we need to focus on deciding what we're going to do with him, considering what he did here over the past 25 years as well as…" she gave him a beleaguered look, "all that other stuff he told us."

"Riiight," Entrapta said. Hordak wondered if she was actually as slow to catch on as she seemed or if she was just playing dumb so she could keep pleading his case, for some unknowable reason. "Well, there's also the point that he's a liiittle bit of a creative genius." Hordak choked on a tiny, shocked gasp and coughed, looking back at her in horror. "I mean, in hindsight he definitely used a lot of his time and effort toward destructive ends, but he also built the entire Fright Zone and kept it running on scrap and reclaimed materials, or else self-sufficient manufacturing processes. Plus, he was the one that developed all the training programs and managed the chains of command that kept that place going, even if he didn't manage the everyday decisions like Catra did. And he did all that while coming up with such *fun* robots!" She shook her fists and beamed. "He always encouraged me to think bigger, and he's *really* good at focusing on goals… maybe to a fault. Actually, definitely to a fault. But I still admire his tenacity and focus!"

Hordak was reeling. He was overwhelmed with her charitable words, but his terror for her reputation overrode all else in his mind. "Entrapta, you need to stop," he hissed at her.

She made a high-pitched noise while she squinted and considered. "Mmmmmmm-no, no I'm sure I want to say all this."

She sniffed. “Anyway, even when he still believed all that crazy nonsense about Prime’s divine grace and suffering-induced purification, I could tell he was worth salvaging.” She gave him a warm look and he shook his head at her. “Plus, people will never listen to you if you don’t treat them like they’re worth saving.”

“Oh, *come on* Entrapta. Don’t tell me you’re trying to *save him from himself* ,” Mermista said in a voice saturated with disdain.

“What? Of course not. I never tried to save him. I never even tried to change him. I just tried to be a good friend, and he figured out the rest on his own.” She gave him a fond look that made his insides flutter and he swallowed nervously. “I decided to give him the benefit of the doubt like he gave me, and we became good friends pretty quickly. He never put a leash on me, and he doesn’t expect me to understand passive aggression- he’s more of an *active* aggression person.” Catra snorted loudly and the princesses suddenly seemed sheepish for some reason. “He was worse at compliments than any of you, but when he said things, I could trust him to lay his meaning out plain for me. I didn't have to wonder if he actually meant what he said, I could just enjoy what he meant. And he’s got problems and imperfections, but…” she paused and a slight flush of color graced her cheeks for a moment before she cleared her throat and continued. “I couldn’t help but like being around him. He’s so easy for me to be friends with. It’s not hard work at all. Even on Beast Island, when I thought he was too busy to send someone to pick me up, I couldn’t help it. That’s why I kept looking for him, even after everything. *Now* I know that he’s stronger than ever, but he’s always been Hordak, underneath all that Prime. He’s always been worth salvaging,” she finished simply. Hordak’s chest was growing sore from how long his hearts had been pounding. He couldn’t begin to process all she’d said. Entrapta lowered herself back into her chair and brought her mask back down over her face as he stared at her. He’d had trouble controlling his breathing several times before, but now he’d stopped breathing altogether.

He turned around and after a few moments, Queen Glimmer spoke as she squinted between Entrapta and himself. “Back on

the ship, when Prime was… he said something about you not wanting to return to him anymore at some point.” Hordak’s stomach clenched as he registered her suspicions. “What was that about?” She fixed him with an intense look.

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.
Cheers.

"...an overgrown goth kid with rage issues..."

Chapter Summary

> Hordak explains his reign of terror in plain terms. Catra can't help someone who doesn't want to be helped. Everyone is generally appalled.

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves.
> Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Back on the ship, when Prime was… he said something about you not wanting to return to him anymore at some point." Hordak's stomach clenched as he registered her suspicions. "What was that about?" Glimmer fixed him with an intense look.

He stalled for a moment, realizing her suspicions and trying to think fast before he had to answer truthfully. "Uh… I had… developed certain doubts… as my friendship with Entrapta developed." Princess Mermista quirked an eyebrow at him and crossed her arms. "Much of what I was learning from her conflicted with Prime's teachings. I didn't want to doubt, I didn't want to question… I continued to follow my sense of duty, but… it's difficult to argue with data," he said haltingly.

"What kind of doubts?" Queen Glimmer asked.

"The… infallibility of Horde Prime… and supposed superiority seemed… incongruous with Entrapta's achievements in the

imperfect," he minced out, trying his best to answer without signs of evasion. "My faith in the benevolent nature of Prime's peace and order also began to… weaken. I had to wonder if the universe I was describing to Entrapta- Prime's universe," he heaved a sigh, "was really something she would be able to love and embrace as I had."

"So you *finally* started to realize Prime was a bad guy, and you decided to just, *keep conquering* ?" Princess Mermista growled, pinching the bridge of her nose briefly before glaring back at him. "Just kept waging war against a whole planet for what… for giggles? *What is wrong with you* ?" she fumed.

"There is… quite a bit wrong with me," Hordak replied stiffly, and was relieved that he could stop his reply there. They seemed to be zeroing in on his darkest secrets, but as his pulse picked up and his hands began to shake again behind the small of his back, he hoped against hope that he might yet escape the most pathetic depths of his shame. He was taking responsibility for his life as a general. With some luck, that would be all he'd have to face this day.

"I'll say," Mermista grumbled before waving her hand at him, apparently as a go-ahead.

"So that's it? Prime was that mad because you were questioning your faith and acting on your own free will? Because it kind of seemed like he *really* hated you. Are you sure there was nothing *else* that ticked him off?" Glimmer was staring at him intently and it seemed she was not the only one with further suspicions. He could tell that the whole room seemed to be be angling at his relationship with Entrapta, but there was more to it than they knew. Yet.

He fought the truth spell with all his might and managed to stall his reply, but George interjected. "Why did he throw you away in the first place? You said you made mistakes but… why did he deem you unworthy?"

His hearts were racing and his mouth had gone dry. He was able to push away memories of Horde Prime's education and reeducation methods, but there was no avoiding why he'd been deemed unworthy. He should have forced himself to plan, to martial excuses, but he'd never had any in the first place. "Prime hates me -hated me- because," Hordak tried his best to resist the truth spell while he focused on slowing his breathing again. On some level he knew he was overreacting, but he couldn't calm his thoughts enough to proceed on bare logic. He looked around himself as he stood in the center of a cramped room surrounded by dozens of people- most of whom had been his sworn enemies until very recently. He'd been operating without his armor under Prime's influence for months without sufficient rest or repair and had gone at least 40 hours without any sleep.

"Uh oh," he heard Entrapta mutter behind him as his hearing muffled and his head swam.

No. No, no, no not here, not now. He could collapse as soon as he was done but not - The truth spell worked regardless of his struggle, and he had to speak through the growing haze. "I am… a…" He was forced to finish the work 'defect' but it was lost in a breathless grunt as he attempted to control his drop into a kneel, hoping to avoid falling over. His knee hit the ground harder than he was ready for, however, and he pressed both hands to the floor, injured arm and shoulder searing with pain. He saw Entrapta's crystal clatter out from his hand and land in front of him. *So much for dignity* , he thought resignedly. At the same time, he felt Entrapta's hands on his shoulders and he drew his bad arm back to cradle against his chest.

"It's okay, you're alright," she murmured to him quietly. He gulped and lifted his head. She'd moved in front of him and hers was the only face he could see clearly. She looked flustered. "Aaahh, I should've made them let you sit," she muttered distractedly before lifting her head to speak more loudly to the room at large. "Don't worry, he's fine, he just needs to rest for a few seconds so his hearts can get some more blood to his brain."

As his senses slowly sharpened again, Hordak realized that the room had erupted into whispers and creaking chairs as people exchanged expressions of shock and confusion, even as all eyes remained on him. As he straightened and Entrapta drew back a little, he saw that Adora and Bow had both stood up and were now hovering, ready to step in. He didn't want a humiliating situation to get worse, so he held a shaking palm up at them until they sat down, still watching him warily. After picking up the pink crystal from the floor where he'd dropped it, he slowly stood and drew his shoulders back, hoping to ameliorate his consuming embarrassment with bearing and poise.

"I am a defect," he finally stated, trying to imbue his words with false bravado as his shame burned white-hot and distracting and he continued to struggle with his breathing.

"Can he maybe have a chair?" Entrapta asked.

Queen Glimmer pursed her lips for a moment before replying, "yeah, he can sit with you and Wrong Hordak. I don't think that'll be a problem," she glanced around herself at her peers, as if seeking reassurance. Nobody responded as Wrong Hordak offered his seat before fetching another from the edge of the room. Once he was settled at the table, he folded his hands before him and leveled what he hoped was a stoic glare at the queen.

After a few moments she continued. "You're a defect? Can you please explain that to us?"

He felt his ears lower slightly against his will as he replied grudgingly. "Something went wrong during my creation… some kind of flaw. I am a defective clone."

"Flaw?" Princess Mermista persisted skeptically. "Or defect, or whatever. Is that what your little episode on the floor was about?"

"Yes," he confirmed with bitterness in his face and voice.

"Is that why your eyes and teeth used to be red instead of green?" Adora asked curiously.

“We are digressing again, but I would assume so,” Hordak replied drily.

“So being defective makes you sick or what?” Princess Mermista asked.

“In a way, yes. There are plenty of aspects that limit or challenge me physically in one way or another, but most debilitating is my vulnerability to injury. The rate of damage accruement seemed to increase once I landed on Etheria and resulted in pain levels that continue to hinder me.”

“How come you weren’t struggling like that on the Velvet Glove?” Catra asked, still sprawled sideways in her chair.

“I… I used to believe that it was Prime’s grace that eased my pain… his divine light. Now I suspect it was some kind of chemical influence instead.”

Catra made a disgusted sound, “Yikes.” Hordak looked down at his hands.

“You seemed just fine while you were razing Salineas,” Princess Mermista pointed out.

“I was wearing the armor Entrapta made. Her technology functioned to bolster my mobility, minimize my pain, and hide my deformations.” He winced upon his last few words, wishing they hadn’t been drawn out by the truth spell.

“Oooh, deformities?” Princess Frosta asked. “Can we see?” Hordak’s blood ran cold.

“Frosta!” Glimmer scolded in disapproval.

“What?” she asked, innocently.

Princess Perfuma spoke up, her features soft and reassuring. “You don’t have to bear any part of yourself that you don’t want to

show. We know from the spell that you're telling the truth," she said kindly.

"Actually," Catra broke in, eyes burning with curiosity and mischief. "It would probably clear up any questions around your threat level once and for all," she crossed her arms. "And maybe then they'd believe I can take you in a fight," she added sulkily.

Hordak tilted his head. "But you've physically subdued me twice, and I wore Entrapta's armor on both occasions."

"That's what I tried to tell them!" she replied enthusiastically.

He glanced around the room at the curious faces and realized that the mystique he'd created around himself over the years had worked better than he'd realized. There was still wariness in their eyes. Not long ago it would have made him proud, but now it made his stomach twist.

"Hordak," Entrapta said softly. He turned to meet her eyes. "We're all on the same side now. You don't have to show them anything. If you want to keep this private, I'll help you."

Hordak glanced around the room again, thinking hard, considering Catra's, Perfuma's, and Entrapta's points. As for himself, he hadn't wanted to tell them anything they'd dragged from him, but despite all his instincts and fears, no one had yet moved to harm him. In addition, such a display of humility and submission would certainly be a significant show of faith. And, he thought as he glanced back at Entrapta again, he wanted to do right by her. "I…" he began hesitantly, "I think I'm ready to remove Prime's armor," he said quietly to Entrapta, who raised her eyebrows as if to ask if he was sure. "It is rather heavy," he reassured her. In truth it *was* heavy, and he was very, very tired. Entrapta nodded, her eyes shining with an unidentifiable emotion.

He remained seated as Entrapta stood and helped him first remove the hooded capelet, and then began unfastening his armor, disconnecting it from his ports and central nervous system

as she went. The room remained silent and he kept his eyes downcast, unwilling to see the expressions of the people around him. Beneath the armor he still wore the dark undersuit, which covered his chest and legs but left his arms, shoulders and ports exposed. Entrapta paused and waited for one more affirmative nod from him before she lifted away the horde armor, which was attached in one piece.

He closed his eyes against the round of whispers that swept the room as he held still for a moment, wasted form on full display. He slowly placed his palms upon the table so that the holes in his forearms were clearly visible and took a deep breath before opening his eyes again. To their credit, most of the Etherians remained composed and expressionless. Catra seemed disturbed and Princess Mermista's expression was unreadable.

The only sound came from Princess Frosta. "Wooooooaaaah," she whispered as she leaned forward and scrunched her nose, staring in close scrutiny. To his own surprise, Hordak had to suppress a smile at the only honest reaction in the room.

"You're very brave," Entrapta whispered so quietly that only he could hear, and he felt his chest, pounding heart and all, swell at her praise. Hearing her words made him *feel* brave, and he lifted his chin at the queen and kept his palms against the table. Now that it was off, he was glad to finally be free of the heavy armor and the horde insignia.

"But you said you made mistakes. Your health problems aren't your mistake," Queen Glimmer said.

"Not only am I defective," he said slowly, "but I, uh, I tried to hide it. Understand, I was not selected from my brothers based on any kind of merit. I was specifically created to be a general, *designed* to hold a position of highest rank. There were only ever about fifteen to thirty generals at a time, and Prime trusted us to manage his military campaigns while he was not personally among us. It was that trust that I betrayed when I hid my defect. I'm sure you can imagine the gravity of this betrayal." He thought

he’d explained himself quite succinctly, but several people shook their heads, absentmindedly. There were also plenty of scowls and exchanged looks.

“Called it,” said a guard who was standing against a wall. She stepped forward and transformed into Double Trouble, who continued. “It took me a while to develop my suspicions, but I figured out his character eventually. I always do.”

“What? How? I had to rip that crystal out of his armor to be sure there was something wrong with him.” Catra spoke flippantly, unfazed by Double Trouble’s sudden appearance. but he heard Entrapta make an angry noise next to him. He looked down at the crystal in his hand and ran his thumb over it.

“He’s seven feet tall, a trained fighter, and quick to anger and violence- so I get being scared of him, really I do,” Double Trouble replied lazily, “but honestly I’m surprised you never saw through the ruse. The skimpy dresses, the guyliner, the brooding... he's an overgrown goth kid with rage issues.” Hordak scowled, unsure of what exactly they had said but sensing that he should be offended. “You don’t vamp like Hordak vamps unless you’re desperate to distract.” They turned to Catra. “And might I add, Kitten, that he’s not the only one with a taste for drama.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Catra asked, frowning.

“You sentenced the warlord's…” they sent a sultry, pointed glance at Hordak, “… *partner* … to a fate worse than death and blamed your mistakes on her so you could climb the ranks of power.” They chuckled as Catra shrank into herself in shame and Adora scowled. “That is some top-caliber scandal.

“Double Trouble, you were not invited to this meeting.” The queen said, pinching the bridge of her nose.

“But I was so curious! And you people are putting such a *marvelous* show.”

"Right, okay- let's stay on track, people. Hordak is sick or disabled or whatever and we all feel bad about what he's been through. We still need to address the issues at hand," Princess Mermista asserted.

"Um, I have a question," Princess Perfuma said next. "Why did you have to be, uh… well, so mean? It seemed like you purposefully did everything you could keep us grieving."

"I did," he confirmed. "The more thoroughly you crush a people's connection to their own identity and historical roots, the less cultural and social resources they have to draw strength from."

"Oh," Perfuma said, and didn't seem to know how to feel about what he said.

"And what about how much you enjoyed destroying Salineas? I've talked with my people, and they said you looked like you were having a great time while you were ruining their lives." Princess Mermista crossed her arms and clenched her jaw, sneering at him.

"Okay, but have you ever blown a bunch of stuff up? It's pretty fun," Catra said before quailing under Mermista's pain and rage.

"The destruction…" he began, building remorse making this reply much more difficult, "felt right. It made being empty make sense. After… everything… I wanted to see Etheria hurt."

"Aaand," Catra interrupted, and it looked like it was taking all of her discipline to force herself to talk. "Part of that is on me."

"Yeah," Mermista replied sullenly, "you don't have to remind me you were there."

"No, I mean," she shifted uncomfortably and glanced at Entrapta. "After… after the portal thing." He couldn't keep himself from clenching his fists and scowling at the floor. "Everything was all messed up, and I thought maybe he was giving up. Maybe he was. But… anyway, I was the only one left to give him a kick in the ass and I convinced him to finish his conquest before Prime

got here. I think we both figured that's how we'd carve a place for ourselves in the coming regime." She blew out a long slow breath and hunched in her chair, shutting her eyes tight for a moment. "Then, I… I kiiind of promoted myself. I showed him I knew how to take him down and effectively removed any ability he'd had to tell me no. I even waited to do that part until after he cleaned up his own sanctum, just in case I accidentally killed him. I kept him as the figurehead of authority so that I'd have somebody to blame fuckups on."

"Cold. As. Ice," Double Trouble said appreciatively.

"So foolish," Hordak was mildly surprised to hear his own voice, breathy with disgust and loathing. "So very, very stupid to think I could earn my way back into Prime's good graces."

"You were lonely and overwhelmed," Adora said, but she was gazing at Catra instead of him.

"Mmm-hmm. A grown-ass man taking comfort in the company of a teenage girl, not creepy at all," Mermista droned sarcastically.

"Cut it out guys," Catra said wearily. Again, she seemed to be forcing herself to speak and he was more confused than ever by her consistent defense of him. "War is hard on everybody." She looked up at him and furrowed her brow. "Also, I can't really imagine Hordak taking *comfort* - he wasn't really a comfort guy. More like, he was just responding to who shouted the loudest." She sighed. "It's a fascist thing but it's not actually one of his crimes. I was stressed and lonely too."

"Uuuuugh," Mermista groaned again. He could tell her frustration was mounting as she turned her glare back on him. "Seriously? You and your stupid issues! How could you ruin so many lives for more than 25 years, just to get what *you* wanted? I literally cannot imagine anything more selfish and cruel and… You had *over 25 years* to learn literally *anything* , but you only ever cared about yourself! You learned *nothing!* " She was slamming her hands on the table in front of her to emphasize her points. "Was it

even about Prime? How do we know you weren't just chasing power for yourself?"

Hordak had no clue how to answer her accusations. The truth spell kept him talking anyway. "My military actions on Etheria were never for the purpose of gratifying personal whims. Though they may have seemed like vanity projects," he glanced at Catra, who raised an eyebrow, "one does not serve prime and oneself at the same time. I did my duty, and I strove to fulfill my duty to the best of my ability and with unwavering faith in Prime."

Princess Mermista didn't answer, she just groaned more and massaged her temples.

Entrapta broke in again. "Considering the social nature of the clones, their aversion to being alone, and the intensity of the bonds they form, I would suggest that his behavior over the years is highly indicative of his mental and emotional state."

When nobody answered, Catra took a stab at clarifying Entrapta's statement for the simpler princesses. "In other words, he wouldn't have been so miserable if he had been doing things that he enjoyed. I don't think he found being a dictator to be very fulfilling." She sighed and cringed, thinking of Prime again. "Scorpia still has a point; even at his worst, Hordak was no Prime. He learned domination from him, but Hordak was always hands-off. I assumed he enjoyed what he did for a long time, but I don't think so anymore. Prime enjoyed it. I know what that looks like."

When nobody argued with her, he knew it was time for him to start pressing his points. The familiar urgency to complete a mission solidified his resolve, even in his cowardice. "On the contrary," he began and waited for all eyes to return to him, "every tool I have ever used to conquer a planet, I learned from Prime. I was one of his generals, which meant that I commanded forces that prepared planets for ascension into the empire. My methods were Prime's strategies and tactics," he lowered his voice to stress the gravity of his words, "and I executed them to the best of my ability. I have spent my life trying to emulate him in all

things and would have done a better job of it here on Etheria if I had access to his technology and hadn't needed to adjust my image in accordance with evolving circumstance. As it stands, I treated the planet as I believed Prime might, and I treated my troops the way Prime treated his. I took what I wanted from innumerable people until they were no longer useful, then I threw them away. I acted with unnecessary cruelty whenever I thought it might increase my power. I did my utmost to crush the people's will to resist and prepare the way for Etheria's ascension."

"Uh… Hordak? Are you sure you want to volunteer that information?" It was Catra again. He glanced up at her strained expression, but then turned through the pain in his side to look at Entrapta, who'd begun twisting her gloved fingers together.

He wanted to tell her how sorry he was, but it wasn't time for that yet. Instead, he tried to give her a meaningful look and said, "I'm sure," before turning back to the queen. "As it stands, I believe I still managed to inflict upon both civilians and military personnel situational attrition, privation, torture, industrial-grade devastation of ecologies and infrastructure *and* the social fabric of communities, large percentages of uprooted population, widespread destruction of private and public property, aggressive military requisitioning, violent and arbitrary upheaval of all aspects of life, and…" he cast about in his mind, trying to think of anything else he might have missed, "unquantifiable and unqualifiable injury to Etherians, physically and emotionally, all of which directly caused countless provable instances of lost life. Beyond the concrete damage I created, I acted as a force of destruction against Etherian cultures, ideas, and value systems. I poisoned your homelands and permanently scarred your people. Not even She-Ra can undo what I've done. There is no repairing what's gone." He had been redundant, but he was satisfied at the impact he'd achieved.

He could have heard a pin drop. Every mouth in the room was open and even Princess Mermista looked too stunned to be angry. Part of him wanted to turn to Entrapta again, but he was afraid of what he might see, so he plunged ahead. "The only reason I used

these tactics in the first place was because I recognized Etheria's potential as an imperial asset and because I lacked the resources for more aggressive domination. When Prime moves -moved- to welcome a planet into his divine light, the approach depended on what the planet had to offer him and the rest of the empire. If a target was rich in exploitable resources, as is Etheria, our tactical approach was designed to preserve these resources to an extent that balanced against the cost in time and energy of subduing the native population. The more time and energy spent in battle, the less importance was placed on preserving resources. I wish to stress that I used siege and occupation rather than scorched-earth tactics out of necessity. If I had access to the armies I'd commanded under Prime, I would have followed his methods of conquest to the best of my ability, regardless of the suffering I caused."

Somber expressions met him around the room. He chanced a glance toward Entrapta, this time moving his whole body to avoid jostling his injuries, but she'd lowered her welding mask. Wrong Hordak's expression was neutral.

"Okaaay," Hordak turned back toward Catra, who looked frazzled as she continued. "But… okay. That's all really, really, *really* bad. But still, you were mostly concerned with the resources thing, right? You never went hog-wild on the population, and… I mean, people… a lot of people got hurt, but our official policy was to minimize collateral damage." She seemed to recoil as she heard her own words.

They still didn't understand. "I told you, I wished to preserve as many exploitable resources as possible."

"Yeah, but…"

The military man with the heart on his chest interrupted her, "people are an exploitable resource, Catra."

Silence fell once again. Hordak wasn't done, but it took some effort for him to continue this time. He could feel his heartrates

slowly pick up again in response to his rising stress. “If Prime deemed that the resources a planet offered weren’t worth the resistance we encountered, the next stage was to switch our tactical approach from policing the population, to dominating them. This approach usually involved surrounding civilian targets one by one in incrementing size, dividing the native population into two groups, and executing one half in front of the other.” Several gasps sounded around him and at least two people began shedding tears in silence. “Unconditional surrender of planetary leaders was usually very swift after this stage began.”

“Is that why you didn’t mind getting so much more aggressive when we went back to fighting after the portal thing? Because we were out of time and Prime was going to pass judgement?” Catra asked quietly.

“Yes.” Hordak heaved a huge sigh, trying to slow his pulse. “If Prime judged that a gentler approach wasn’t worth the manpower, we were to release the planet back into the shadows it had chosen to cling to.”

“…cleansed by light before a terrible and eternal night…” Wrong Hordak chanted vacantly in a singsong murmur, almost as if to himself. Several people shuddered, including Hordak.

“By inclusion, domination, or cleansing, the ascension of a world was inevitable once we set foot there.” He shook his head slowly. “I never imagined it could be any different until Etheria proved Prime… proved me wrong. Proved once and for all that…” he swallowed, still struggling with the enormity of the truth, “that it was all for nothing.” He screwed up his face, horrified to feel his eyes burning as he held the attention of the room, fighting to control his breath and clenching his shaking hands into fists, placing Entrapta’s crystal on the table so as not to cut his palm. “Everything I ever did, everyone I ever hurt… it was all for nothing. All of the suffering... utterly meaningless.” He finally lapsed into silence. That was it. It was *finally* all out. The rest, with any luck, was between himself and Horde Prime.

“How many planets did you do that to, Hordak?” Adora asked, eyes shining with unshed tears.

“I don’t remember,” he said, forcing himself to hold her gaze. “I was a part of the hivemind and hadn’t been alive for very long before Prime cast me out, but… I was an… enthusiastic servant.”

She closed her eyes and two large tears rolled down either cheek. He was too cowardly to look at anybody else’s expression, so he returned his gaze to the queen’s table.

“Why did you tell us all of that?” This time King Micah spoke, pure hatred in his voice.

“Because” he said as he prepared for his next step, “I want everyone present to be extremely clear on the decisions that will be made here today.”

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.
Cheers.

End Notes

Lors of nods and references to other fanfics and like some borrowed shit throughout, just because I've soaked it up at some point and I either don't realize it or I don't remember where I got it. If you recognize what something comes form, then you remember more than I do and I encourage you to make mention of it in a comment or something. I’m not trying to be an asshole, just scattered. Also, if you think I should tag something that I didn’t, let me know. Cheers.

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